A SHORT BOOK

Rational, Spiritual, Practical

A modern take on the path from micro to macro

by Alex

Version 7.13.0

Contents

PART ZERO

Before you start

PART ONE

Rational

PART TWO

Spiritual

PART THREE

Practical

AFTER THE BOOK

Stay in contact

PART ZERO

Before you start

Who is talking and what each part is for.



I'm Alex. I work in cyber security, and my spiritual search has run for more than fourteen years. In many ways I'm a modern monk with a day job, living in a kind of neo-monastery.

If you've ever seen a monk, Buddhist or Christian, someone who took the serious spiritual path in one of the religions, and thought to yourself, I want that too, minus the religion: that's pretty much what I thought and felt when I chose this life.

This book is here to convey ideas. It isn't a course, because a method is learned from people, the way a craft is. It has three parts, and each one has a

different job.

Part one is the rational part, and I've kept it deliberately earthly. It uses no spiritual vocabulary. It is about two things you can check in your own life, how much you make things happen and how much you let go of whatever holds you back, and why almost nobody works on both. Its two words, DO and BE, carry the rest of the book. It's also the part you can hand to a partner or a friend who rolls their eyes at the word spiritual. And if someone handed this book to you, Part one was written with you in mind.

Part two is the spiritual part: where all of this comes from and where it leads. It starts from one assumption about reality, quotes many traditions, and it is what I actually believe.

Part three is the practical side: the conditions that make it realistic to walk the whole road in one life, from the ones you can start alone tonight to the ones that need other people.

One more thing before you start. This book says plainly what I've lived and what I believe, and you're free to disagree with any of it. Use whatever holds up in your own life and put the rest down.

PART ONE

Rational

Two directions, four rooms, and a map that turns out to be bigger than it looks.

Two questions

Two questions first. Nobody is checking, so you can be honest.

How many things have you said you would do, and then didn't? Keep it to the last month. We're not here to ruin your evening.

And how often are you the first one to make a move in a conflict? The first “okay, that one was on me,” the first message after the long silence?

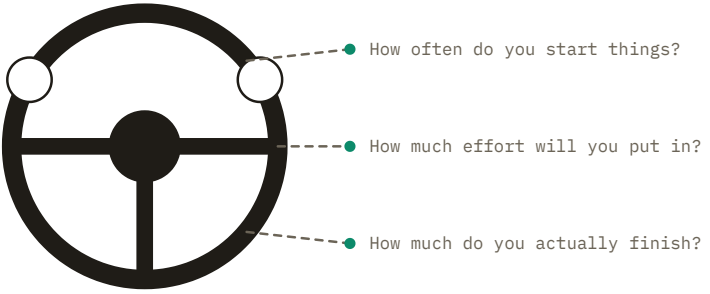
Hold on to your two answers. They measure two different things, and almost nobody works on both. I call them DO and BE. DO is how much you make things happen. BE is how much you let go of whatever holds you back from the inside, which turns out to be how much you can be here, aware of what is actually happening right now. When both are high, I call it high agency, and the few people who get there live a different kind of life.

This part is one graph, drawn slowly.

DO: making things happen

Start with the easy one, since everybody already agrees it matters.

Picture the steering wheel of your life. Either you're holding it or you're in the back seat. How much of your life happens because you made it happen, and how much of it just happens to you?

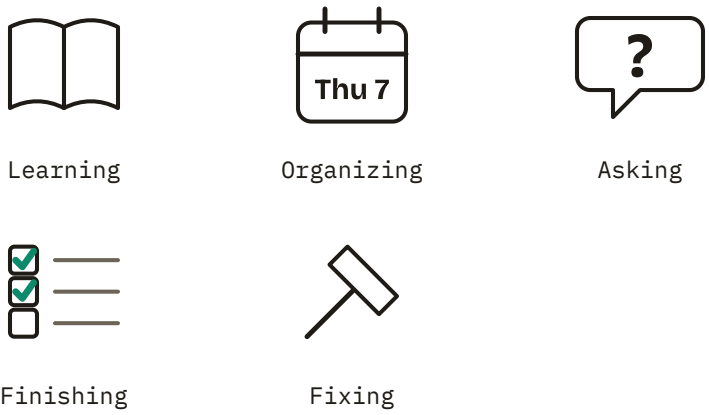


Front seat or back seat?

Hands on the wheel, or in the back seat.

The simplest test is a boring one: do you follow up on your words? That's most of it. It doesn't need a loud personality, and it doesn't need a world-changing project. Making a plan for the day and then following it counts for more than most world-changing projects, which tend to live in the notes app.

The quiet kinds of DO tell you more than the loud ones. Learning something new is one, because for weeks you're bad at it in private. Organizing is another: somebody has to turn "we should catch up sometime" into Thursday at seven, and picking the restaurant is the hardest outer-agency test most groups ever face. Asking counts, out loud, for the raise or the help, instead of hoping somebody notices. So does finishing the form and the dentist appointment that has been "next week" for a year. And fixing the squeaky door. If you've been going to fix it for a year, you've been running a free experiment on yourself, and the results are in.



Five quiet kinds of DO.

The big kind has a trap of its own. Dreaming about changing your whole life is a very comfortable way of not taking today's small step. You can't pick up the guitar yet, because first you'd have to quit your job and move somewhere with a music scene.

I call this outer agency. You did something on purpose, and afterwards your life has something in it that wasn't going to show up on its own.

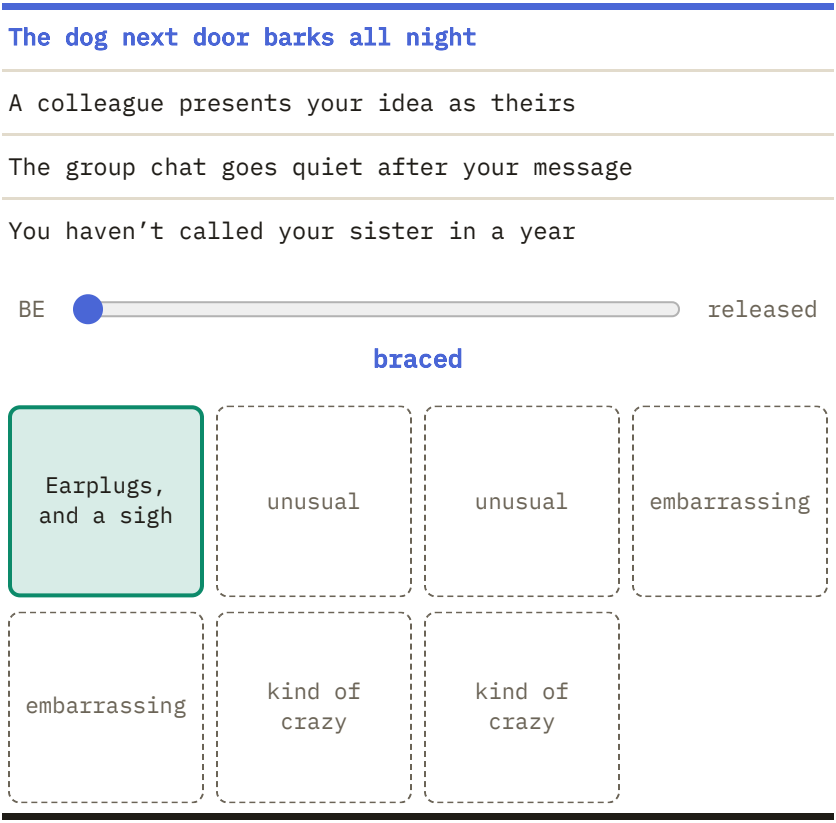
BE: letting go, and being here

BE gets talked about much less, and it's the more interesting of the two. DO is playing your instrument better. BE is improving the quality of the instrument itself.

BE is being at ease with yourself and being here. Letting go is how you get there. It's showing your inner world to another person without three days of rehearsal. It's how much you believe your own fears, and how much other people's opinions push

you around. It's also where the kind part of a person lives, because that part switches off whenever you're braced.

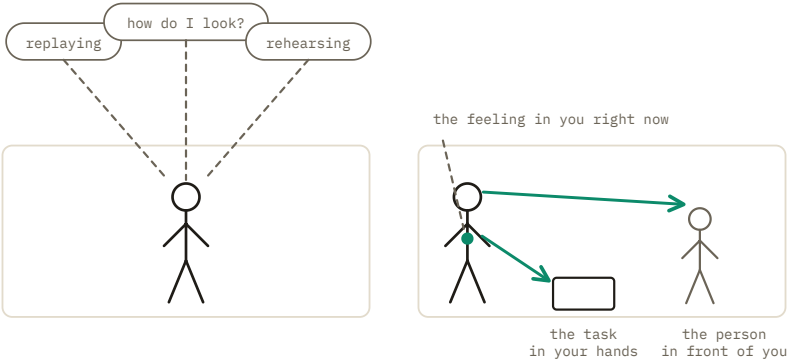
It matters even if you couldn't care less about being a nice person. Fears and doubts sit in the body as tension, and tension is a tax on your ability to see solutions. Carry enough of it and there is a whole shelf of solutions you never look at, because they're unusual, or embarrassing, or kind of crazy, and you ruled them out before you noticed you were deciding anything. You fall back on the answer already in your head, and you pay the tax on every problem you meet. In 2016 a Go program made a move against one of the best players in the world that commentators took for a mistake, because no professional would play there. It helped win the game. Whatever else it had, it didn't have the belief that you don't play there. Jonny Miller's essay "How to Unclench" uses the same tax image and goes much deeper than I will.



You took the only book you could see, and the dog keeps barking.

Here is the connection to being here. Tension pulls your attention out of the moment, into replaying what happened, rehearsing what might go wrong, checking how you look. Your body is in the room

and your attention is in a meeting that isn't happening. When researchers pinged people's phones at random moments, their minds were somewhere else almost half the time, and they were less happy for it (Killingsworth and Gilbert, 2010). The more you let go, the more your attention stays here. The more you stay here, the sooner you notice a feeling while it's happening, which is the moment it can move. That's why letting go and being here sit on one axis.



Braced: body here, attention elsewhere

Here: attention on what is going on

Where your attention is, as opposed to where your body is.

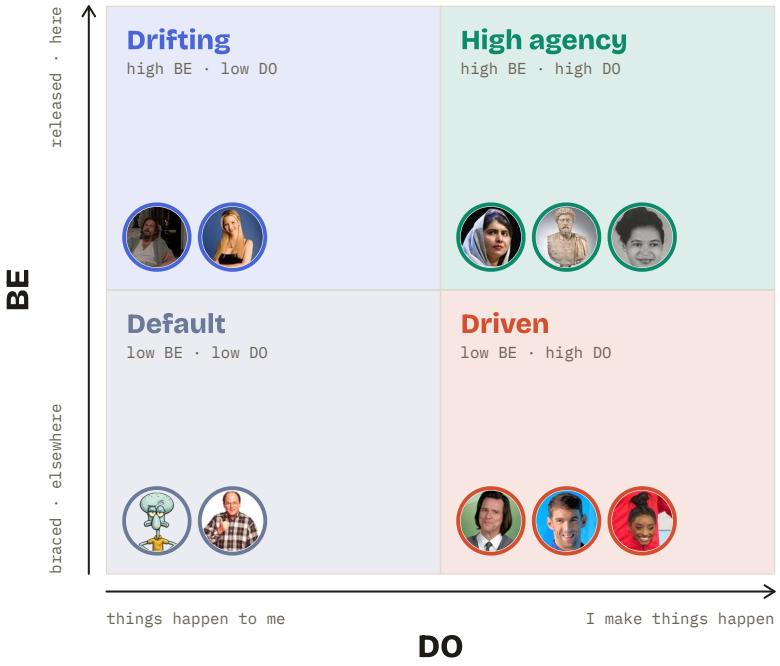
I don't mean relaxed, because you can be relaxed and asleep. I mean released: free from your own internal limitations, and more here, not less.

So how do you move up BE? Meditation helps a lot. What moves it most is the thing nobody wants to do: admit you were wrong and take the first step toward fixing it. Say sorry, and mean it. Have the hard conversation, feel the "oh no, I really don't want to" go through you, and do it anyway. If you already say sorry for everything to keep the peace, your hard step is the other one: saying what you need, or saying no.

That is an act against your own resistance, and I call it inner agency. Outer agency moves you along DO and gets things done. Inner agency moves you up BE and gets you unstuck. Both are ways of expressing who you are, effectively, and that is all agency means here. So letting go, the one that sounds soft, is a high-agency skill.

Four rooms

Draw them as a cross. DO runs left to right, from things happen to me to I make things happen. BE runs bottom to top, from braced and elsewhere to released and here. You get four rooms, and each has a few famous residents, because a chart with nobody on it is just algebra.



The cross. DO runs left to right, BE runs bottom to top. Each room with the people who will show up in it.

Default

Bottom left: low BE and low DO. Things happen to you, and you're braced for the next one. You say a lot, and you follow through on a fraction of it. Roughly 95% of us live here. From the outside a lot

of it looks like laziness. It's usually fear, and fear is busy: it burns a lot of energy where nobody can see it, on doubt and regret and replaying.



Squidward

Squidward is the most extreme case and the funniest. He complains constantly, all his problems live next door, and he dreams of being a famous artist and clarinetist. When he does try, it goes badly and he blames everybody else. In one episode he moves to a town full of people exactly like him, and the sameness drives him up the wall.

There's a line going around that you either die a SpongeBob or live long enough to become a Squidward. Kids are born relaxed. They're joyful, they do things, and nobody has told them yet what's impossible. Over time life adds ideas, doubts and fears, and we start taking them seriously.



George Costanza is the exit story. He lives with his parents, has no job and believes everything his head tells him. Then Jerry tells him that if every

George Costanza

instinct he has ever had is wrong, the opposite must be right. George does the opposite of every fear he has, and by the end of the episode he has a girl, a job and a bit of respect. It isn't the perfect way out of this room. I also can't tell you it doesn't work.



Henry David Thoreau

Default has a nice corner too, near the middle, where the decent, functional people live. They keep their word most of the time and apologize sometimes. They have a job, a few friends and something they do on weekends, and nothing is on fire. A lot of them feel ok, just a little flat, and there's a word for the flat part: languishing, a term from the sociologist Corey Keyes that Adam Grant made popular. You're not depressed, and you're not thriving. You're meh. Thoreau noticed the same thing back in the 1850s. In Walden he wrote that most people lead lives of quiet desperation. That's this corner: people who went along with the life expected of them and never got around to asking

whether it was theirs. The desperation is quiet because it hardly feels like desperation. It feels like Tuesday.



Hank Hill



Jim Halpert



Pam Beesly

Hank Hill is that corner at its most lovable. He's responsible, kind and loyal, he has opinions about lawns that border on a belief system, and he can barely say "I love you" out loud. Jim Halpert is the relaxed version, good at a job he treats for years as temporary. Pam Beesly sits a few feet away, a receptionist who wants to be an artist and takes years to do anything about it.

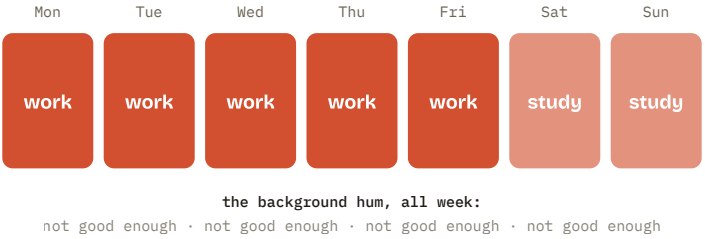
What makes this room sticky is that it feels like making your own decisions. A retreat is three or four days away from the regular rhythm of life, a chance to practice mindfulness and look at where you're going. On one, people get a small instruction for a few days, something like not touching the

phone for a few hours. I've watched people catch themselves with it in their hand anyway, without having decided anything, and on my first retreat I was one of them. The mind decided, and we just did it. That's Default from the inside: the body on autopilot and the attention somewhere else.

Driven

Bottom right: low BE and high DO. Still tense, because nothing has been let go, but these people get things done. You know some. You may be one. I was.

With my personality tendencies, it was a natural fit. For a few years I gave myself to a career in cyber security: working all week, studying on the weekends, with a constant background tension of not being good enough and not much time for the questions I'd started with, or for my wish to help other people live happier lives. I did become quite good at it. Luckily, something stopped me, and it came from the inside.

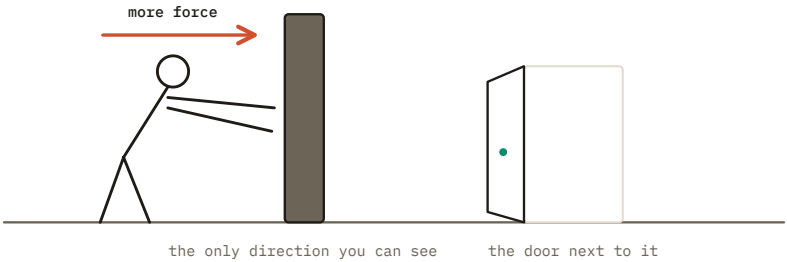


Work all week, study on the weekends, with a constant background tension of not being good enough.

The hours aren't what makes this room. Plenty of people work long days toward something they love. What makes it is the quality of the hours, and underneath there is usually an "I'll prove them wrong," or an "I'll get it done and then people will like me." It's a lack the person can't let go of, so they push harder in the one direction they know. Our culture pushes the same way. Almost every idea we have about success comes from this room.

This room builds companies and wins medals and answers its email. The cost is the tax from earlier. With enough tension, the only tool you can see is more force, so when a problem doesn't move you

push harder in the same direction. For a long time that works. Then it stops working, and the person has no second move.



When a problem does not move, push harder in the same direction.

You can spot it by the finish line, which keeps moving: when I get this, then I'll relax, and when this arrives there's a new this. Which raises a good question: what happens when a driven person actually reaches the dream?



Jim Carrey

Jim Carrey is one answer. He reached about everything an actor can reach, and he has talked openly about years of depression. He has said everybody

should get rich and famous and have everything they ever dreamed of, so they'd see it isn't the answer.



Michael Phelps

Michael Phelps is the same story, counted in medals: 28 Olympic medals, 23 of them gold, more than anyone in history. By his own account he crashed after every Olympics, and in 2014 he checked into a treatment center. He has said he had always seen himself as a swimmer and not as a human being. Going into London in 2012 he wanted nothing to do with the sport anymore, and he says Rio in 2016 felt nothing like that.



Simone Biles

Simone Biles is the most decorated gymnast in history. In Tokyo in 2021, mid-air, something stopped working the way it always had. She pulled out of the team final and said why that same day: mental health. She came back for the beam and won bronze, and in Paris she won three golds. I won't tell you which room she lives in now. That's her business.



Tal
Ben-Shahar

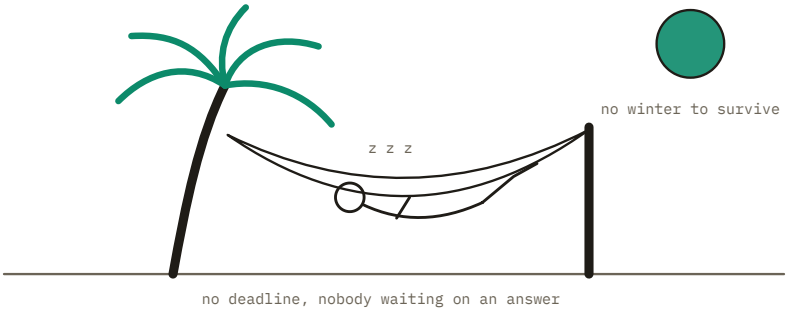
Tal Ben-Shahar has a name for what Carrey and Phelps ran into: the arrival fallacy, the belief that once you arrive you'll finally feel the way you've been chasing. You arrive, you get a few days of relief, and the old tension is still there, now with a nicer view. In my case the tension was "not good enough," and I can confirm it is a productive thing to run on, up to a point.

Busy is a very respectable way to never sit with yourself, and almost nobody gets an intervention for working too hard. They get promoted. Even the tools of letting go get recruited: meditation for focus, Stoic quotes on the lock screen. The engine underneath, a point to prove or approval to earn, keeps running. It just has a nicer morning routine now.

Drifting

Top left: released and passive, high BE and low DO. I call them drifters, fondly, because I was a pretty good one. Until I was about 24, before my Driven

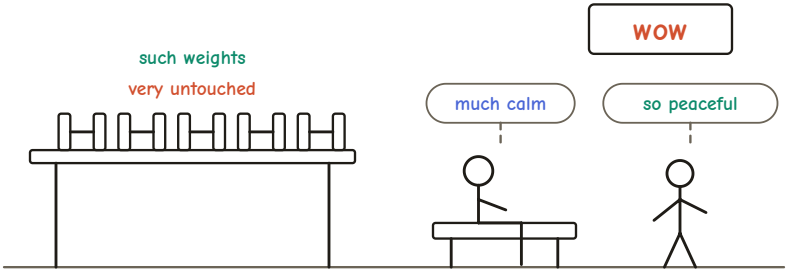
years, I was a kind of spiritual drifter, with big ideas and not much done. The room is full of relaxed, kind people you'd happily spend an afternoon with, who do very little. The room is about DO, and income has nothing to do with it: a nurse on night shifts is doing plenty and lives nowhere near here. It happens when life rarely pushes you from the outside, which in my case it didn't, so I had plenty of time for big ideas. Several of them are still ideas, and they're very comfortable where they are.



Where life rarely pushes you from the outside.

The trap is that it feels good, and the good feeling is real. But look at what is producing the calm. Mostly it's that nothing is pushing on you: no deadline, no colleague who irritates you, no relative asking when

you're getting a real job. Calm that depends on nobody asking anything of you lasts exactly until somebody asks. The explanations help it along: the timing isn't right, wanting things is just stress, everything happens when it's meant to. Each has a grain of truth, which is why they work. So does the long stay somewhere warm to figure out what I want. It can be exactly right, and it turns into the trap when it replaces the conversation you can't face.



Very peaceful. Much calm. Nobody gets hurt and nobody gets stronger.



The Dude

The best-known example is the Dude from The Big Lebowski, which is my favorite film, so you can see how I ended up in here. He is the chillest

person ever put on screen, and most of the plot is other people's plans happening to him. He is loved for it, and for good reason. I'd just like him to own a calendar.



Phoebe Buffay

Phoebe from Friends is the Dude with a guitar: kind, odd, loved by her friends, floating through life on instinct. She's the happiest resident of this room and still a resident.

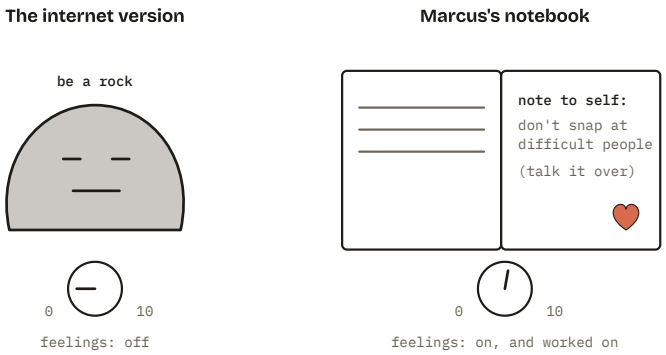


John Welwood

John Welwood, an American psychologist and long-time Buddhist practitioner, coined a term in the 1980s for those escape moves: spiritual bypassing, using spiritual ideas and practices to avoid your own problems. Running off to an island for a long meditation so you never have to face one relationship is the obvious version. Notice what gets skipped: the sorry, the hard conversation, the first step in a conflict, the whole inner agency list. Bypassing is a very sophisticated way of never having to do any of it.

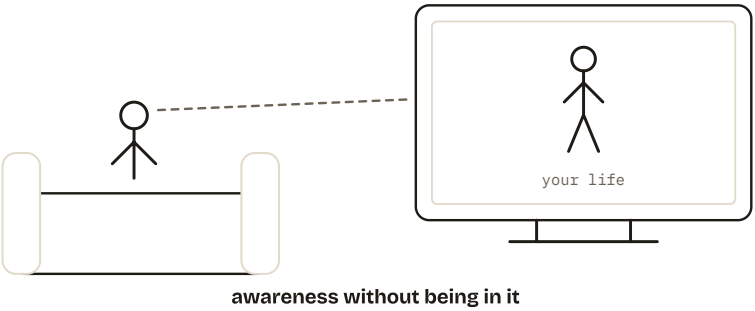
Almost every tradition that works on letting go gets shortened the same way, to the part that sounds like permission. Mainstream spirituality teaches people to live in this room. It tells you to be present and let go, which you need, and says very little about getting up and doing something, which you need just as much.

Take Stoicism, because the internet version is so popular. Some things are up to you and a lot aren't, so put your effort into the first and make peace with the second. The popular version adds one more step: then I shouldn't feel anything. Be a rock. Marcus Aurelius's private notebook is full of him reminding himself not to snap at difficult people, and a man without feelings wouldn't need the notes. Advaita Vedanta, the Indian school of non-duality, goes the same way. It says the separate self is an appearance, and read on a weekend that turns into: there is no doer, so nothing is my responsibility, and the world is an illusion, so why answer that message. The traditional route asked for preparation and ethical living first. The quick version keeps the punchline and loses the setup.



Stoicism, misread and as practiced.

The extreme version of this room is the person who learned to watch their thoughts without getting pulled in, which is a real skill, and kept going until they were watching their whole life from the side, like a documentary about somebody else. Ask how they are and they'll tell you, sincerely, that they have no problems. Super calm. Boring calm. I was heading that way myself, and I met people who fixed my silly ideas about it before I got there. You need to open your heart, not just your attention. Calm that costs you your feelings isn't release. It's anesthesia.



Aware of everything, in none of it.

High agency

Top right: released and active, high BE and high DO. You've let go of enough to be here, and you act from there. It's also turbulent.

A quick way to find your own examples is a test from George Mack, who wrote the essay on high agency. You're in a third-world jail cell. Who do you call? Whoever you just thought of is the highest-agency person you know: capable enough to do something about it, and caring enough to bother.

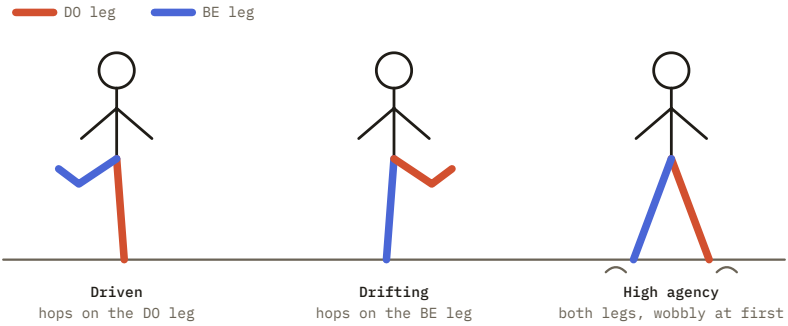


The jail-cell test.

Look at the person you picked. They treat a problem as solvable until it proves otherwise, so “what can I do about this” comes long before “whose fault is it.” They don’t wait for permission. They can be disagreeable when it’s needed, and never for sport. They own their part in a mess without turning it into a punishment. And they care, which is what separates agency from ruthlessness. You can be capable without caring. You just wouldn’t have called that person from the jail cell.

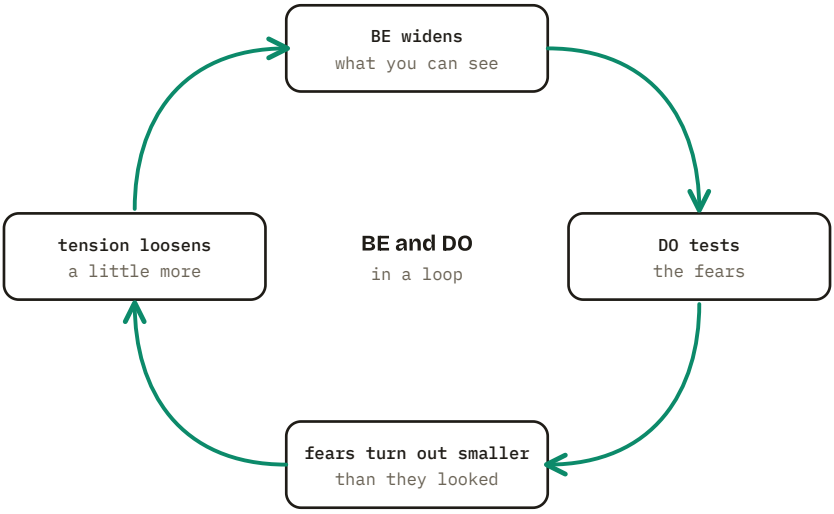
The turbulence comes from walking on two legs. In Driven you hop on the DO leg. In Drifting you hop on the BE leg. Here you finally put both down, and

walking turns out to be hard. Every step swings to one side or the other until you find the center.



Three ways to move. The DO leg is vermilion, the BE leg is blue.

Here is why the turbulence is worth it: the two legs feed each other. BE widens what you can see, so you notice more things worth doing. Doing them tests the fears that kept you from looking, and most of those fears turn out smaller than they looked. Each one that fails the test loosens the tension a little more. George Costanza ran this experiment for one episode. A person who keeps it up for years looks less like someone balancing two things and more like someone doing one thing, with a bit of a dance in it.



The two legs feed each other.



Malala Yousafzai

Malala Yousafzai kept going to school under the Taliban, wrote an anonymous blog for the BBC and spoke out on national television, all at eleven. At fifteen she was shot in the head on her school bus. She survived, built a global movement for girls' education, won the Nobel Peace Prize at seventeen and then got an Oxford degree, which after that list sounds almost modest. In her speech at the UN she said she doesn't even hate the man who shot her. That's both legs in one person.



Marcus Aurelius

Marcus Aurelius ran the Roman Empire for nineteen years with a plague in it, a long war on the frontier, and a general who declared himself emperor behind his back. On campaign he wrote notes to himself that we now call the Meditations, a man with the largest to-do list on earth reminding himself to do the task in front of him and stop being run by other people's opinions. When the usurper was killed, the ancient sources say, Marcus was upset he'd lost the chance to pardon him. We also have a pretty cool statue of him.



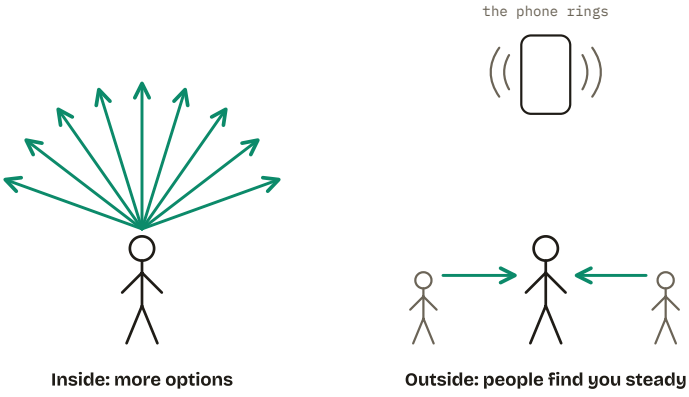
Rosa Parks

Rosa Parks is a good one for anyone who thinks this room needs a loud personality. She was a soft-spoken seamstress who had worked with the local NAACP chapter for years before the day in 1955 when she refused to give up her bus seat in Montgomery. She said later that the only tired she was, was tired of giving in. Then came decades of steady, unglamorous work.

Fiction has one too: Sean Maguire in Good Will Hunting, a community college teacher with a quiet life and his own grief, who at the moment it matters finds the one sentence that gets through: “It’s not your fault.” The person you called from the jail cell lives here too, most likely with no statue and no prize.

What the top right gives you

So what do you get for walking on both legs?



The top right, from the inside and from the outside.

From the inside, you're here for your own life. You see more options, because the tax stops being collected, and more problems start to look solvable. Your reactions get shorter, and so does the time you stay angry at somebody. You say sorry faster, because the relationship matters more to you than being right. Emotions still arrive, and they go through you without a fight. Big challenges get more interesting and small things get more joyful, which is a strange combination and the best one I know. A lot of people who get here describe it as being in love with life.

You can receive, too: help, praise, a day off. And you say the nice things out loud. From a very young age I felt weird telling people to their faces how I feel about them, and unexpressed gratitude and love sit in you as tension, just like unexpressed anger does.

From the outside, people find you steady and warm. You say what you think, and you don't use it as a weapon. When somebody is having a hard moment you can help them through it, instead of climbing

into the mess with them. And you become, mostly by accident, the person someone calls from the jail cell. Don't be surprised when the phone rings.

At the far corner of the chart is the peak, where nothing feels impossible. Almost everybody has visited. Programmers call it flow, athletes call it the zone, musicians call it the muse, and the rest of us call it a good day. Being in love is the preview: for a few weeks everything is good and you feel like you can do anything, and nothing outside you changed. An athlete can live in the zone for ninety minutes and lose it in the parking lot. Everybody visits, and almost nobody lives there.



Programmers
flow



Athletes
the zone



Musicians
the muse



The rest of us
a good day



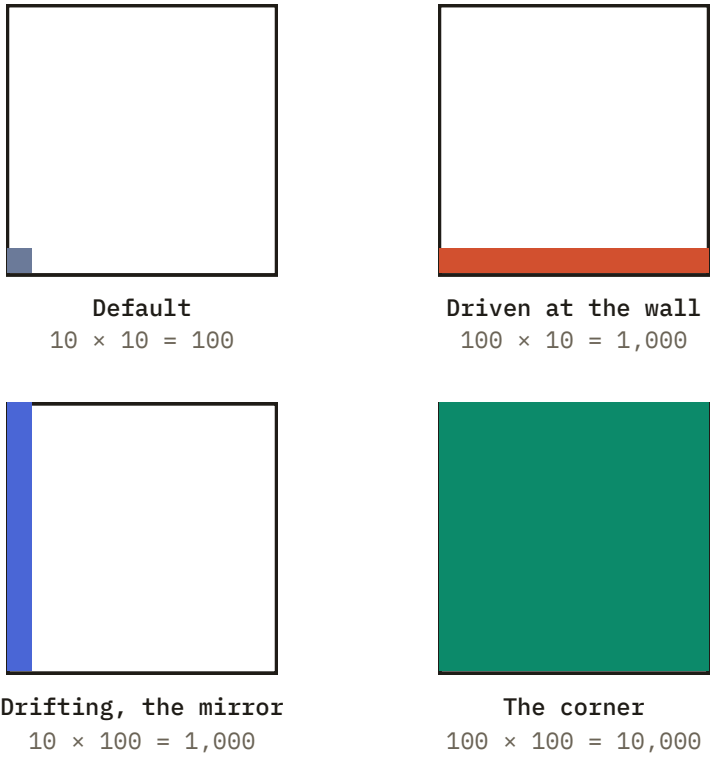
Everyone
being in love

Different rooms, same visit.

The math

Say BE and DO each run from 0 to 100, and how much of your potential you use is one times the other. With no DO, freedom changes nothing outside you. With no BE, all the action goes down the few paths your fears allow. Someone at 100 on DO and 1 on BE gets 100. Give up five points of DO, gain one of BE, and it's 95 times 2, which is 190, just from being slightly less busy.

Picture the whole chart as a square, 10,000 in all. Default takes up 100, Driven at the wall or Drifting at its mirror 1,000, and the corner all of it.



The same square, four ways. Width is DO, height is BE, the shaded part is the area a person takes up.

Driven people usually object that if they let go of the tension they'll lose their edge. The drive and the tension are two different things that most of us have

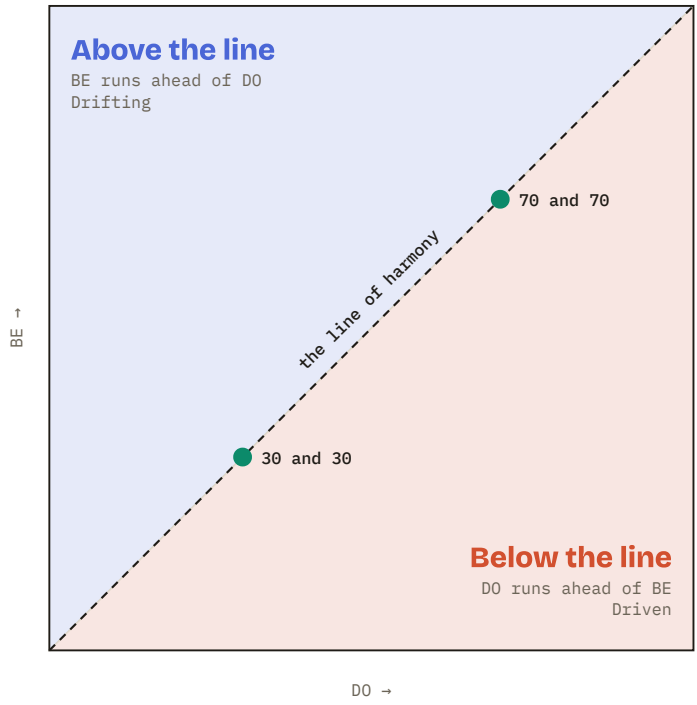
glued together. You keep the drive and drop the brace. Phelps in Rio is the closest famous example I have, and I'm a smaller one. Most of the tension from my Driven years is gone, and the drive grew. I used to lose a lot of time to video games and shows, and now I want to work on my goals every day. I get more done, it satisfies me much more, and the goals got bigger.

On one project I was investigating an incident and couldn't find how the attacker had gotten into the system. In my Driven years that's where the panic would start, the feeling that I'm failing. This time there was a calm in me that just knew something would crack. It did. The answer was the very thing I had been searching for at the start, with one last twist, and it was quite simple. It just took me a while to see it.

The line

Now draw a line from the bottom left corner to the top right. Every point on it has as much BE as DO. I call it the line of harmony.

On the line, what you're free to want on the inside is in step with what you can do on the outside. You don't need to be anywhere special on it. Someone at 30 and 30 is on the line, and so is someone at 70 and 70. Position along the line says how far you've come. Distance from it says how much is leaking.



The line of harmony. Position along it says how far you have come. Distance from it says how much is leaking.

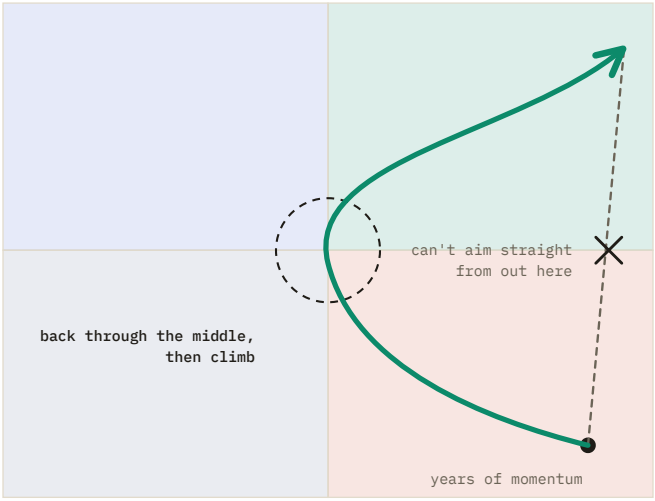
Below the line, in Driven, the outside runs ahead of the inside, so the doing often points at something that was never really yours, and when the results arrive nothing inside says thank you. Above it, in

Drifting, there's plenty of freedom inside, not much to show for it outside, and a very comfortable gap between the wishes and the doing.

Why almost nobody stays

If the corner is so good, why isn't everybody there? Because you can't steer to it from an extreme.

The reason is inertia. Someone deep in Driven has years of momentum in one direction, and someone deep in Drifting has the same momentum the other way, so neither can turn and aim at the corner. The route goes back through the middle first. The driven person eases off, the drifter starts moving, and only from the middle can either of them climb. Nobody does that for fun, so usually something has to stop them first.

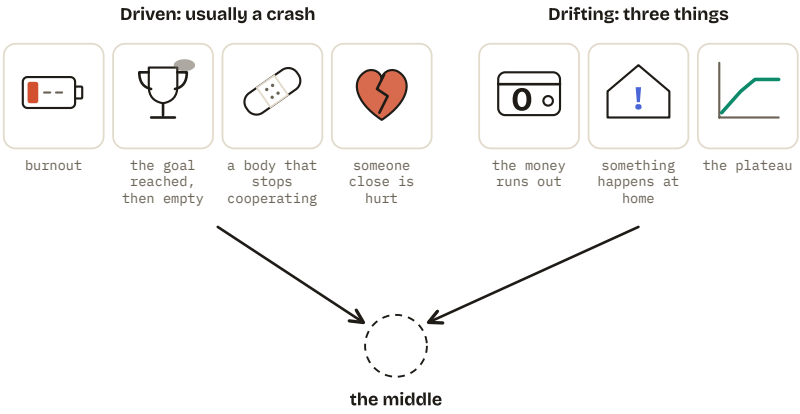


inertia: the route to the corner goes through the middle

Inertia.

For a driven person it's usually a crash: burnout, depression after reaching the goal, a body that stops cooperating, or a shift in values when a relative ends up in the hospital. Jim Carrey made far fewer movies after 2014, said in 2022 that he'd done enough, and then came back for another Sonic movie. In my case it came from the inside. Whenever I had time to myself I felt an emptiness that none of my results could touch, and it made my weekends the worst part of the week. Under it was a wish to know myself more deeply.

For a drifter I've noticed three things. The first is that the money runs out. I know that sounds stupid, and I'm serious. When a person waits long enough for life to sort itself out, life arranges a situation where they can't cover what they need. The cause is the waiting, and money is just the most common way it shows up. No matter how spiritual a person is, reality has a way of reminding us about itself. It works from both sides, by the way: the driven person gets the same reminder when there is finally plenty of money and nothing inside has changed. The second is that something happens, usually in the family, and they can't stay passive anymore. The third is the plateau. Years of calm, nothing changing, and one day it all looks like a waste of time. Then, instead of stopping in the middle, they swing all the way across: screw this, I'm getting a job.



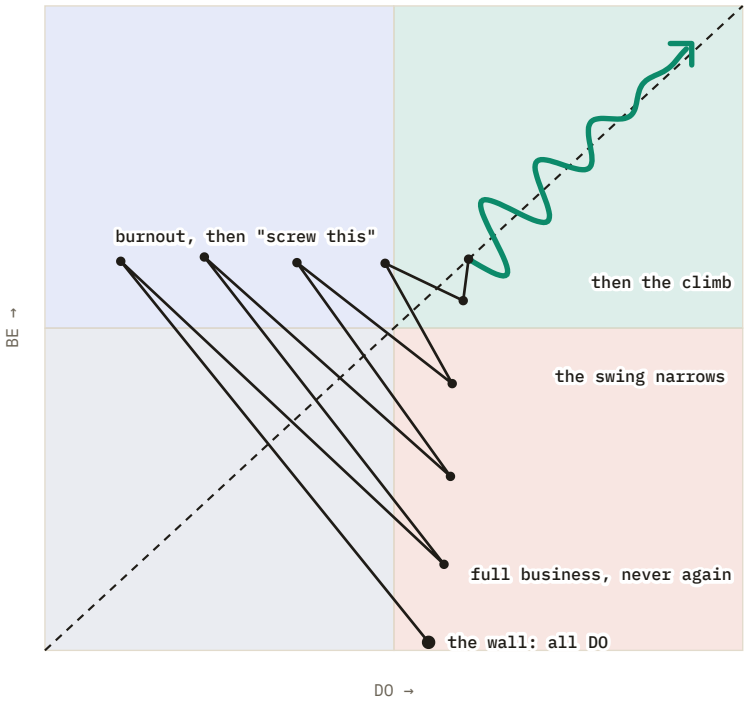
What stops each room, and where it points: the middle.

That's why people swing. Driven people swing hard into Drifting: burnout, then a one-way ticket to a tropical island. Drifting people swing hard back: I'm going full business, never again. I know people from both directions.

One friend of mine is the cleanest example: a founder who built a company and did very well, and who was also, in my friend's own words, one of the most tense people you could meet. Family trips to beautiful places were miserable every second, because there was no way to enjoy any of it. When the old way stopped working, my friend went on a retreat and, for a while, stopped. On the chart,

that's coming off the wall back toward the middle, and then climbing, with the action kept the whole way. It shows at home. My friend has real patience now with the kids, neither of whom is very calm, and can talk with someone about what's going on inside, calmly and with care.

Learning to walk on two legs looks wonky for a reason. A toddler doesn't walk so much as fall forward in a controlled way, sometimes into the coffee table. Adults are the same. At the beginning we overshoot, hard one way and hard the other, and that's how you learn it. Trace a life on the chart and you see a zigzag that keeps narrowing.



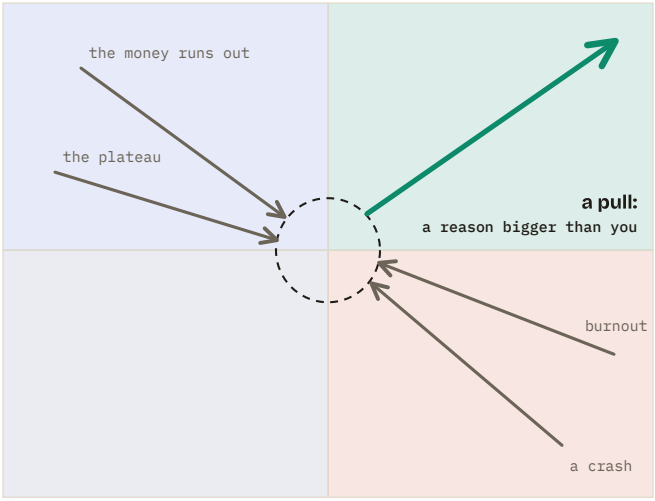
A swing that narrows, then the climb, which stays wavy until the peak. Illustration, not data.

The reason bigger than you

Everything so far has been a push: the money runs out, the body stops cooperating, the plateau gets old. Pushes work, and then they end. The money

comes back, the body recovers, and the person drifts back to wherever they were comfortable.

What gets someone across the middle on purpose is a pull. Plenty of people try to get there by being a bit less driven and a bit more relaxed, circling the edge of it for years. The result is usually a driven person who meditates and is slightly more effective. What carries a person across is a reason bigger than themselves. “I’ll prove them wrong” turns into “I want to help people do something.” Or “I have kids, and I want to be a better person for them.” Anything that matters more to you than your own wants, needs and fears can do it, however small it looks from outside.



pushes bring you to the middle; a pull takes you across

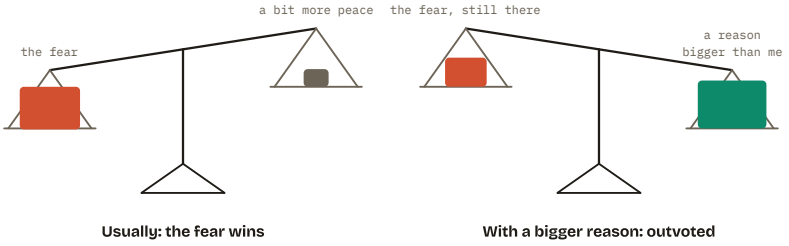
Pushes and a pull.



Viktor Frankl

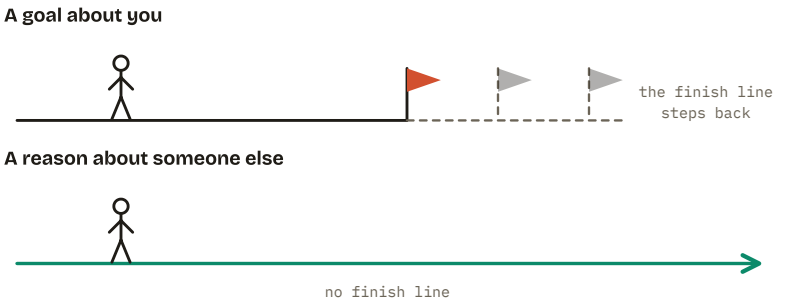
Viktor Frankl, a psychiatrist who survived the Nazi camps, saw a human being as always pointed beyond themselves, at a meaning to fulfill or a person to love. Self-actualization, he wrote, comes only as a side effect of self-transcendence. Chase yourself directly and you miss. Serve something and you get yourself as a bonus. In the camps he saw that people who had a "why" could bear an astonishing amount of "how," a line he borrowed from Nietzsche.

Picture someone who freezes whenever they have to speak up for themselves: the awkward email, the raise. Now picture the same person at a school meeting, speaking up for their kid, calm and specific and a little scary. Same person, same nerves. The fear got outvoted. Tension is a vote against anything that puts you at risk, looking wrong, being rejected, losing control, and it usually wins because what's on the other side of the scale is small and about you. A reason bigger than you is a bigger vote. The fear can still be there. It just stops deciding.



The fear is a vote. A bigger reason is a bigger vote.

Reasons also outlast goals. A goal about you ends when you reach it, and what's left can feel like nothing. Graduates who reached goals about growth, relationships and community were doing better a year later, and those who reached goals about money and image weren't (Niemiec and colleagues, 2009). A reason about someone else has no finish line. Nobody finishes raising a kid.



Goals about you end. Reasons about others keep going.

The same fix works for both rooms, because the drifter and the driven person have the same hole: their reason is about them. The drifter's reason is their own peace, which takes little action to keep. The driven person's is their own proof, which never gets enough. A bigger reason gives the drifter

something worth getting up for and gives the driven person permission to stop proving. It also damps the swing. A swing is your direction set by your mood, and a reason doesn't have a mood. It won't make you less tired. It makes you less likely to quit the whole thing on a Tuesday.

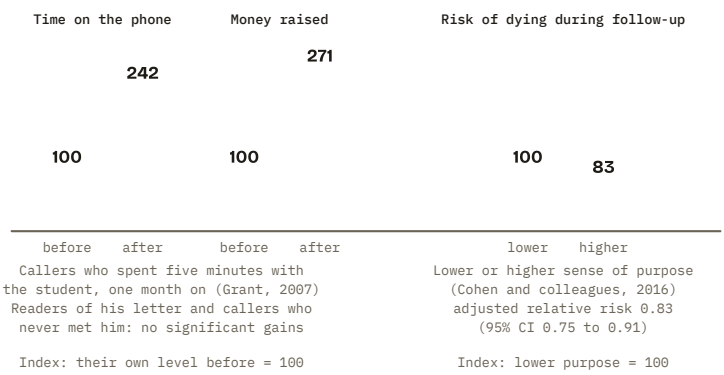
FROM THE STUDIES · 6 STUDIES

What the studies say

- In two studies that followed college students week by week, students whose goals were about supporting other people got less distressed as the term went on, and students whose goals were about looking good got more distressed (Crocker and colleagues, 2010).
- In four studies with more than two thousand young people, a purpose aimed beyond the self helped them stick with a boring task and later improved their grades (Yeager and colleagues, 2014).
- In a small experiment, people nudged to think about helping others had lower stress-hormone responses to a public speaking

test, though they didn't report feeling less anxious (Abelson and colleagues, 2014). Their bodies calmed down before their feelings did.

- University fundraisers spent five minutes with a student who had received a scholarship. A month later they were spending 142% more time on the phone and raising 171% more money than before, while callers who only read his letter showed no significant gains (Grant and colleagues, 2007).
- A long study of older adults found that volunteering went with a lower risk of dying over four years only when the motive was other people (Konrath and colleagues, 2012).
- A review of ten studies and more than 136,000 people found that those with a stronger sense of purpose had about 17% lower risk of dying during the follow-up (Cohen and colleagues, 2016). It's an association, so I'm not claiming that a bigger reason will add years to your life. The direction is the same in nearly everything I could find.



Left: a randomized field experiment. Right: a review of ten long-term studies, which shows an association, not a cause. Read both as a direction.

Look back at the high agency room. Malala had girls' education. Rosa Parks had a cause she'd been working on for years before the bus. Marcus Aurelius wrote that he got up in the morning to do the work of a human being. Different centuries, temperaments and jobs, and the same thing underneath: a reason that wasn't about them.

Bigger doesn't have to mean grand. It only has to be bigger than you: a kid, a team, a craft, a person who relies on you. A New Year's resolution is a reason

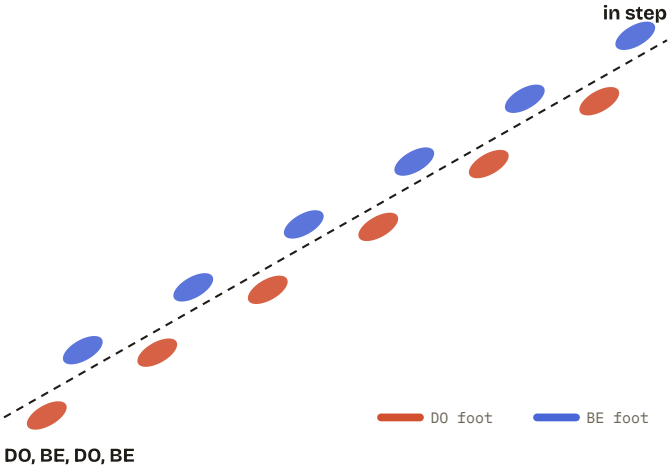
about you, which is why it tends to expire in February.

It does have to be real, though. “I want to help people” can be the driven person’s new costume, the same engine with a halo. Two questions tell them apart. Would you still do it if nobody ever found out? And does it make you gentler with the person in front of you, or does that person turn into material for the cause? Bigger than you doesn’t mean instead of you, either: people who look after others to the exclusion of themselves report more distress (Fritz and Helgeson, 1998).

Harmony as the road

Put it together. The road to the top right is a road to harmony between what you want on the inside, what you can do on the outside, and what you have to work with right now. The way there is to keep

catching up the lazy leg until the two walk in step. Pushing the strong one harder only gets you a faster hop.



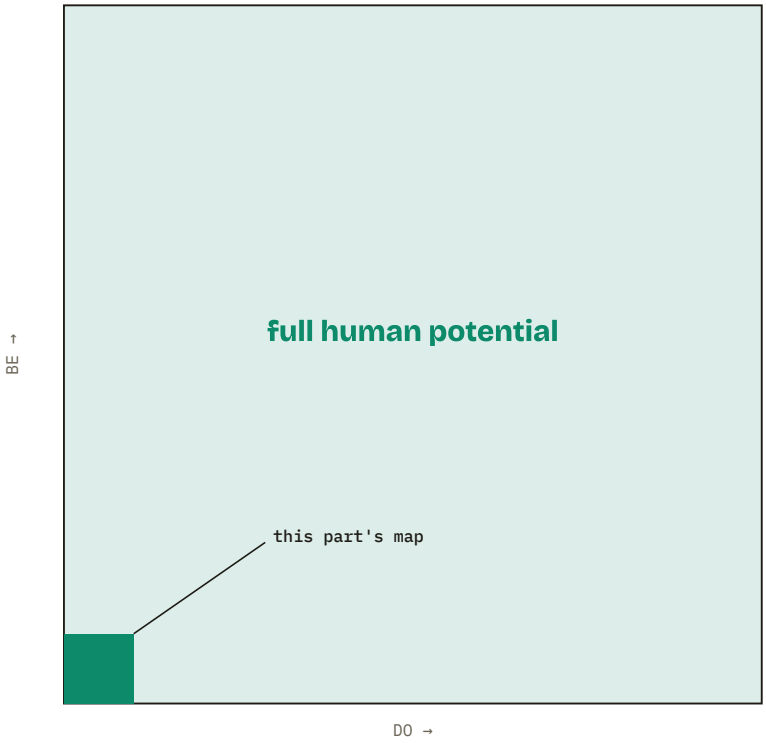
Walking in step: the lazy leg catches up, again and again.

You can check which way you're moving at any time. How many options do you see right now, compared with a year ago? When did you last do something nobody asked you to do, for somebody else's good?

Zoom out

One correction before this part ends. The top right corner is the peak of this chart, and this chart is a small part of a much bigger map.

Zoom out, and the whole square we've been using shrinks to a small box in the bottom left corner. A person can grow into all of that area, and I like the plain term for it: full human potential. Most people have stood at its edge for a moment without a name for it, under a sky full of stars or holding a newborn, when for a minute nothing felt separate. Those moments don't fit anywhere on this chart.



Zoom out. The whole square we have been using is the small box in the corner.

Sources

CREDITED IN THE TEXT

- Miller, J. (2026, September 16). How to Unclench. The Inner Frontier. howtounclench.com
- Mack, G. High Agency in 30 Minutes. highagency.com

THE REASON BIGGER THAN YOU

- Frankl, V. E. Man's Search for Meaning. Boston: Beacon Press, 2006 edition, Parts One and Two.
- Crocker, J., Canevello, A., Breines, J. G., & Flynn, H. (2010). Interpersonal goals and change in anxiety and dysphoria in first-semester college students. Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 98(6), 1009-1024. doi:10.1037/a0019400
- Yeager, D. S., et al. (2014). Boring but important: A self-transcendent purpose for learning fosters academic self-regulation. Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 107(4), 559-580. doi:10.1037/a0037637
- Konrath, S., Fuhrel-Forbis, A., Lou, A., & Brown, S. (2012). Motives for volunteering are associated with mortality risk in older adults. Health Psychology, 31(1), 87-96. doi:10.1037/a0025226
- Abelson, J. L., et al. (2014). Brief cognitive intervention can modulate neuroendocrine stress responses to the Trier Social Stress Test: Buffering effects of a compassionate goal orientation. Psychoneuroendocrinology, 44, 60-70. doi:10.1016/j.psyneuen.2014.02.016

- Cohen, R., Bavishi, C., & Rozanski, A. (2016). Purpose in life and its relationship to all-cause mortality and cardiovascular events: A meta-analysis. Psychosomatic Medicine, 78(2), 122-133. doi:10.1097/PSY.0000000000000274

- Killingsworth, M. A., & Gilbert, D. T. (2010). A wandering mind is an unhappy mind. Science, 330(6006), 932. doi:10.1126/science.1192439

- Niemiec, C. P., Ryan, R. M., & Deci, E. L. (2009). The path taken: Consequences of attaining intrinsic and extrinsic aspirations in post-college life. Journal of Research in Personality, 43(3), 291-306. doi:10.1016/j.jrp.2008.09.001

- Grant, A. M., et al. (2007). Impact and the art of motivation maintenance: The effects of contact with beneficiaries on persistence behavior. Organizational Behavior and Human Decision Processes, 103(1), 53-67. doi:10.1016/j.obhdp.2006.05.004

- Fritz, H. L., & Helgeson, V. S. (1998). Distinctions of unmitigated communion from communion: Self-neglect and overinvolvement with others. Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 75(1), 121-140.

PART TWO

Spiritual

Two ways of reading a life, one assumption that separates them, and what follows from it in the world's religions.

Where we part ways

Part one was the polite part. Everything in it holds up whichever way you think the universe works, and this is where we part ways. Most people would call the top right corner of that chart the goal. I'd call it the edge, because the whole chart rests on one quiet assumption: that I'm a separate thing, and a separate thing has to protect itself and take what it

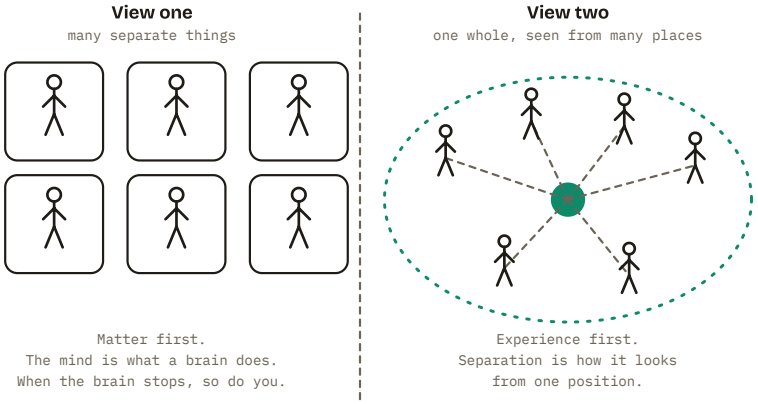
needs. If you'd rather have a practical next step, Part three is for you, and you can come back here any time.

Start with something you've had. You're in the shower, thinking about nothing, and the answer to the thing you were stuck on all week just turns up. Or it's late, someone you love calls and needs help, and from somewhere you get a second wind. Where did that come from?

The first answer starts from what you can see: a world of things, and underneath them particles. A mind is something a brain does, and when the brain stops, the experiencer stops. Here the idea in the shower was your brain finishing its homework in the background.

The second view sits at the other extreme, and it starts from a different assumption: that we are part of something bigger. There is one shared consciousness, and each life, yours and mine, is an individual experience of it. I'm one of the places the whole looks out from, with the memory of the rest switched off for a while. Most people have felt a

moment of it, holding a newborn maybe, or on a quiet evening by the sea, when the line between you and everything else went thin.



Two assumptions at opposite ends. Neither can be observed from outside, since the observing is done by the same mind.

Here the idea and the second wind came from the whole, and the word I use for the whole, as it shows up from inside one life, is source. Think of the sun. Nearly all the energy in your breakfast started out as sunlight, and the sun shines on everybody, whether they think about it or not. The source is on all the time and reaches everyone, and what changes from one person to the next is how much of

it gets through. If source sounds like too much, call it life, or connection. What matters is noticing the moments when there's more of it. The times I've felt it most came with the same sensation: that I'm not alone, that I have a lot of energy at my disposal, and that I can do whatever I set my intention to. And each time, the biggest wish that came with it was to share that state with other people.

So why does being separate feel so convincing? That question is most of this part.

Why this idea is worth a closer look

I'm not religious, and I'm not asking you to adopt anybody's religion. I'll quote a lot of traditions because, in their own words, they keep coming back to this idea. Hindu texts say it outright, Judaism, Christianity and Islam say it in their mystical layers and in a few plain verses, Daoism says that the many come from one, and Buddhism

and Jainism come at it from another side. People with no creed say it too. Spinoza argued that there is only one substance, which he called God or Nature, and Carl Sagan said on television in 1980 that we are a way for the cosmos to know itself.

Agreement settles nothing by itself, so I'll take the idea as true and show what follows from it, one step at a time. You can judge it by that.

FROM THE TRADITIONS · 6 PASSAGES

The base, tradition by tradition

- Hinduism: in the Chandogya Upanishad, one of India's oldest texts, a father tells his son that the finest essence is the self of the whole world, and that he is that.
- Buddhism comes at it from another side. The early discourses teach that none of the parts that make up a person is my self, and later schools say that nothing exists on its own. One school of Chinese Buddhism pictured that as a net of jewels in which each jewel reflects all the others.

- Judaism: the central prayer, the Shema, says that the Lord is one, and Chabad, a Hasidic movement, reads that unity as including the world: from God's side the world is as nothing before him, while from ours it is real.
- Christianity: Jesus prays that his followers may all be one, just as you, Father, are in me, and I in you, and Paul ends his account of the end with God being all in all.
- Islam: the Quran says that wherever you turn there is the face of God, and the Sufi mystic Ibn Arabi called all things "He/not He," meaning that each thing is God and also not God.
- Daoism: in the Daodejing the Way gives birth to one, one gives birth to two, and the sequence runs on to the ten thousand things, the Chinese phrase for everything that exists.

The axiom and the machine

The axiom has three clauses.

We are part of something bigger. There is one shared consciousness, a single whole, and everything is a part of it.

The whole experiences separation. It looks at itself through individual lives, each one a position with its own point of view, which each of us experiences as “my life.”

The separation ends. Being separate is a phase, and it returns to knowing itself as one. You can see the direction in small things: each time two people stop being strangers to each other, a little of it ends.

The first two clauses describe how things are. The third says where they go, and it is the one the rest of this part leans on most.

> A CLOSER LOOK
>
> **But why would it do that?**

- Here explaining runs out, for me and for everybody else. The materialist picture has the same edge: the Big Bang is where our equations stop, so asking what came before it, or why it happened at all, leaves the question nowhere to stand. The axiom has its own version of that edge. It says that the whole experiences separation, and it can't really say why a whole would want to.
- What I do have is a story Alan Watts used to tell, and I enjoy thinking about it this way. Watts was the British writer who spent his life explaining Eastern philosophy to Western audiences, and the talk is usually called "The Dream of Life." Suppose that every night you could dream any dream you wanted, and pack seventy-five years of experience into a single night. The first nights you would have every pleasure you could think of. After enough of those you would get tired of always knowing how it goes, so one night you would dream something you don't control, where things happen to you that you didn't plan. Each night

you would hide a little more from yourself and take a bigger gamble, because the not knowing is where the excitement is. Keep going, Watts says, and eventually you would dream the life you are living today.

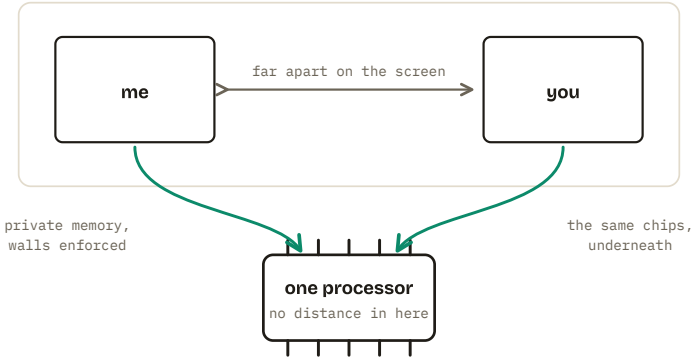
- That's the second clause told as a story, and it makes the forgetting part of the fun. A dream like that only works if the dreamer forgets, and a whole that still remembered being whole would be wearing a costume and knowing it. So if you ask me why the whole would bother, I have two answers, and I like them together. The first is Watts's: it got bored of knowing how everything ends. The second matters more to me. A whole with nothing outside itself has nobody to love, because love needs someone else, someone you can reach for and come back to. So the whole became many and forgot that it had, and now each part gets to find the others and love them. Seen that way, the separation is what makes love possible at all.

I'll hold it with a computer, since I spent years in cyber security. Picture one machine running thousands of programs. Each program gets its own private memory and believes it has the whole thing to itself. The operating system maps all of it onto the same physical chips, and the hardware enforces the walls, which is what keeps a random app away from your password manager. The walls are real, though engineers built them. Underneath, there is one machine.

Now picture the screen. Two windows sit in opposite corners, and there seems to be a distance between them. There is a distance, on the screen. Both windows are computed on the same machine in the same moment, and the machine has never heard of that distance.

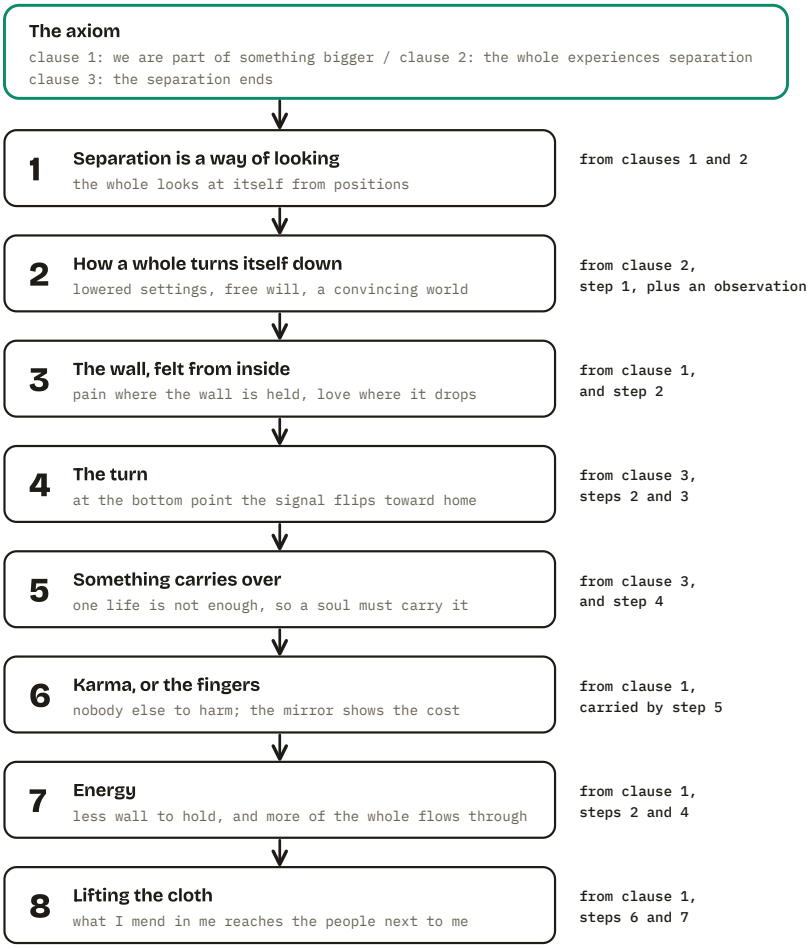
Under the axiom, you and I are programs. "Me over here, you over there" is the screen. My private memory is the self I feel from inside. The wall around it is the felt edge of me. The whole is the

machine that was running both of us all along. The computer is a picture. It doesn't mean the universe is a simulation or that anyone is running it.



Far apart on the screen, side by side in the machine. The distance is a property of the drawing.

From these three clauses I want to build the rest one step at a time. Each step uses a clause of the axiom, an earlier step, or both, and in a few places I add something I have observed, and I'll say where. Under each step I'll show you what the traditions say, so you can judge for yourself whether they meant the same thing. Here is the whole chain on one page.



The chain. The arrows show the order. The tags on the right give the premises each step uses, which are not always the step above.

1. Separation is a way of looking

If everything is part of one whole, and the whole experiences separation, then being separate can't be a fact about what exists. It has to be a fact about how the whole is looking at itself. So the separation is real as an experience and misleading as a final description, and that's what I mean by illusion. The word gets misused. It doesn't mean nothing is there. The distance between the two windows is real, and you can measure it with a ruler held to the screen. What's wrong is the reading, the thought that two separate things sit that far apart inside the machine. The walls between programs work the same way. From inside a program they are completely real, and they still don't mean the machine is in pieces.

The traditions give answers to why a whole would do this, and they rhyme. Hindu texts call creation lila, play, an activity with no need behind it. Which makes the universe the biggest hobby project ever,

and like every hobby project, nobody can explain why it took this long. A whole that looks at itself needs positions to look from, and a position is a separation. Knowing needs a gap.

FROM THE TRADITIONS · 3 PASSAGES

Real as an experience, misleading as the last word

- Hinduism calls the appearance maya, and teachers of Advaita, the non-dual school of Hindu philosophy, warn that “illusion” translates the word badly: the world depends on something deeper for its being, so it is neither fully real nor simply unreal. Plato’s prisoners in the cave take shadows for the world, and in the Heart Sutra, a short Buddhist text, form is emptiness and emptiness is form, which Buddhists read as saying that things have no fixed independent nature of their own.
- The Brahma Sutra (2.1.33), a classic Hindu text on the Upanishads, is where creation is called lila. Sufis quote a saying, “I was a hidden treasure and I loved to be known,” which

scholars of hadith, the reported sayings of the Prophet Muhammad, do not accept as his. Its logic is the one I just gave: a whole that wants to know itself needs a point of view.

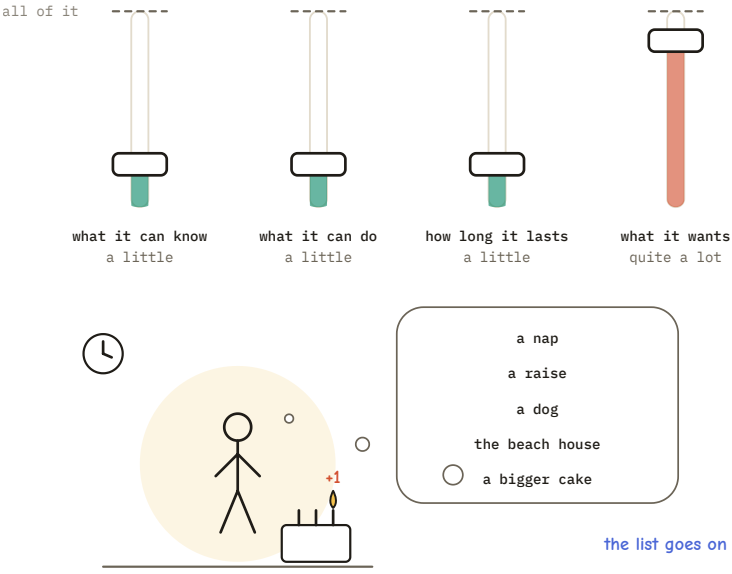
- Ralph Waldo Emerson, who had left the pulpit, wrote in The Over-Soul in 1841 that we live in succession, in division, in parts, in particles, and that meanwhile within man is the soul of the whole.

2. How a whole turns itself down

How does something whole manage to look at itself as a part? There is nothing outside it that could do that, so it has to be something the whole does to itself.

My answer is that it takes doing less. A whole that can do anything can also do less than everything, so picture it turning down four settings for one point

of view. What it can know, so it sees only what is near. What it can do, so it acts only within reach. Time, so its life has a before and an after. And need, a feeling of not having enough yet, so that it reaches for things. Set all four low and you get someone who knows a little, can do a little, lasts a little and wants quite a lot, which is a fair description of me before coffee.

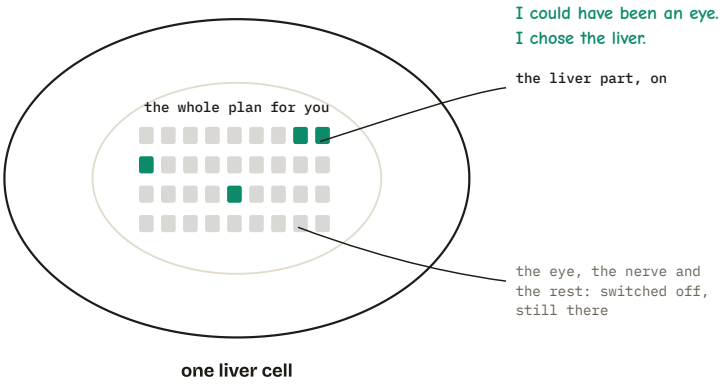


You and me, most days

It sees what is near, it reaches what is near, it gets one more candle on the cake every year, and its wish list grows faster than the candles. Most of us live here, and it is where every good story starts.

Your own body does it too. Almost every cell carries the full plan for you, and a liver cell uses a small part of it, with the rest switched off and kept. John Gurdon and Shinya Yamanaka shared a Nobel Prize for showing that the parts switched off can be

switched back on. A cell with every setting on would be no use to the body. The lowered settings are what give the part its job.



Every cell carries the whole plan and uses a small part of it. The rest is switched off and kept.

Lowered settings are half of it. The other half is a world that agrees with them. Every body hurts on its own, every object has an edge, every life has its own bills and its own birthday, and each time you check, all of it says you are in here and the rest is out there. The traditions call this lila, the play, and maya, the appearance. It's made so well that the

whole, looking through it, believes it, the way you cry at a film while knowing perfectly well that the dog is an actor.

One more thing is needed. A part running a script written in advance would just be the whole reading itself a story. So the whole hands over the steering, and that is free will. You don't choose the rules or what each choice costs. You do choose what you do, and nothing in the steps ahead forces the way back.

FROM THE TRADITIONS · 5 PASSAGES

Cloaks, contraction and the steering

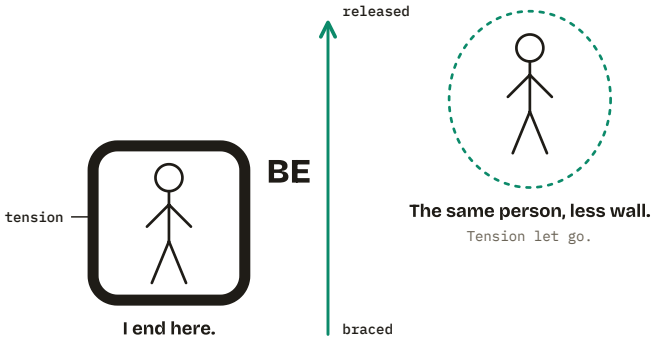
- Kashmir Shaivism, a school of Hindu philosophy whose name, Pratyabhijna, means recognition, teaches that the One narrows itself into a person through five cloaks: limited power to act, limited knowledge, a sense of lack that makes us reach for things, time, and a fixed order of cause and place. Its short text, the Pratyabhijnahrdayam, presents the path as recognizing what you are.
- Isaac Luria, the sixteenth-century Kabbalist of Safed, taught tzimtzum: the Infinite withdraws

into itself to leave a space in which a world can exist.

- Jain teaching describes karma as fine matter that veils the soul's own natural knowledge, as clouds veil the sun, so the perfection was there all along.
- In the Chandogya Upanishad (6.13) a father has his son put salt in water and come back the next morning. The salt can't be seen, and it is in every sip. Then comes the refrain from 6.8.7: that is the self, and you are that.
- In the Mishnah, Rabbi Akiva says that everything is foreseen, and freedom of choice is given (Avot 3:15, numbered 3:16 in some editions). As I read it, that is this whole point in one line: the whole sees everything and still hands over the steering.

The body holds the limits in place. The belief that I'm separate is held there as tension. Clench a fist and you feel like a small hard thing among other

things, and when you open it the feeling softens. That tension is the wall.



The wall, as it shows in the body. Hold less of it and you sit higher on BE.

Left alone, the wall gets thicker. A world built to help a whole forget keeps doing its job, so if you do nothing in particular, every year you're a little more guarded and a little more sure of where you end. Give it enough years and you start sentences with "back in my day". Something else has to start the return.

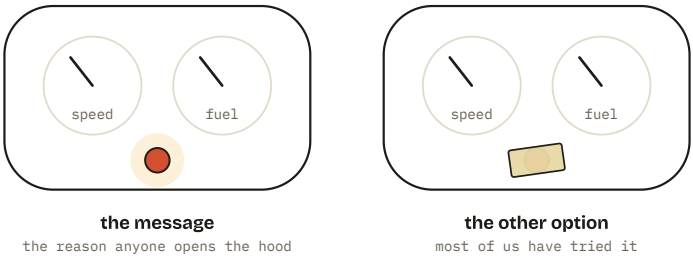
3. The wall, felt from inside

Start with pain. Some of it is the body doing its job: you touch a hot pan and your hand pulls back before you've had a single thought. Then there is the part we add on top. When something hurts, the tension that holds the wall closes around the pain and says this shouldn't be happening. Most of what we call suffering is that, the pain plus our fight against it. So suffering measures resistance. The more you push against what is happening, the more it hurts.

I know this one from my own life. Most of the friends I grew up with, and I'm still friends with them, have a partner, and some have kids. Relationships have never come easily to me, and for many years I didn't know whether I even wanted one. Looking back, what caused me the most suffering on the subject was how much time my mind spent on that question. That was the part I added on top.

The pain itself is a signal, and most of the time it asks for something to be done. If it's your body, go to a doctor. If it's a person hurting you, fight back or leave. Letting go drops only the layer on top, the inner fight against the fact that this is happening, and without it the next move is usually easier to see.

Measuring resistance gives suffering a job. Left alone, the wall only gets thicker, so something has to report what it costs, in a way we can't simply ignore. Suffering is that report. It works like the warning light on a car's dashboard. Nobody enjoys seeing it come on, and it is the only reason anyone opens the hood. Putting a piece of tape over it is also an option, and most of us have tried that at some point.



the message
the reason anyone opens the hood

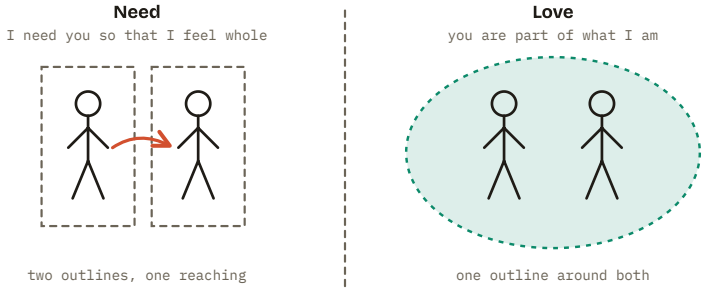
the other option
most of us have tried it

Suffering as the warning light on the dashboard. The tape is also an option.

The same signal reads the other way. When the wall drops for a moment, what you feel is love. A child runs at you and you pick them up, or a friend says exactly what you needed to hear, and for a second you don't notice where you end. Under the axiom it feels good because for that second you are acting as what you are, a part of one whole. Part one called being in love the preview of the far corner of its chart, and this is what the preview shows.

That's also why love is strongest with the people closest to you, where the wall is thinnest. It helps to tell love apart from need, since the two live in the same relationships. Need says, I need you so that I feel whole. Love says, you are part of what I am.

Most of us have plenty of both, me included, and the work is to grow the second. Need keeps score of who did the dishes last. Love just does them, which I'm told is very attractive.



Need says, I need you so that I feel whole. Love says, you are part of what I am.

That leaves the hardest question. If we are all part of one whole, why does it allow cruelty? There is nobody else, so the whole is on both sides of everything that happens, the one who hurts and the one who is hurt. And a steering wheel that could only turn toward kindness wouldn't be a steering wheel. What we call evil is what a point of view does when its wall is at its thickest: it acts as if the other is no part of it at all. Augustine said that evil is the absence of good, the way a shadow is only a place

where the light isn't getting through, and under the axiom that is exactly right. Evil is love that is missing. Knowing what cruelty is never asks anyone to stand by, and step 6 says where it lands.

So pain and love are one signal, read in two directions. Over one evening that's a mood. Over a year it is a direction.

FROM THE TRADITIONS · 5 PASSAGES

Two arrows, two halves and the absence of good

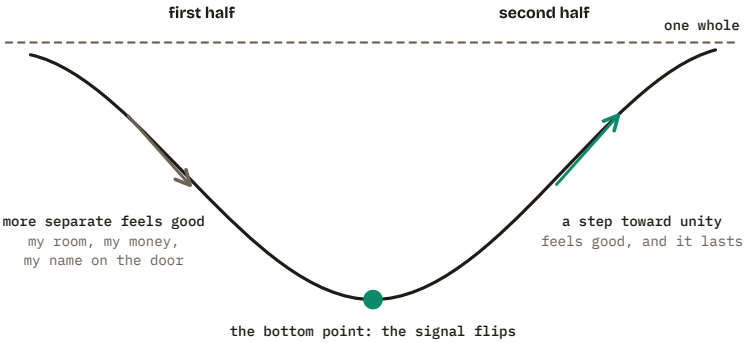
- In the Sallatha Sutta he says that when something hurts, an untrained person feels two pains, the physical one and the mental one added on top, like a man struck by one arrow and then by a second, while a trained disciple feels only the first (Samyutta Nikaya 36.6).
- Augustine asks in his Enchiridion what we call evil if not the absence of good, and compares it to a disease or a wound in the body, which is the absence of health and does not exist on its own (chapter 11).

- In Plato's Symposium, Aristophanes tells a comic story in which humans were once whole and were cut in two, so each of us goes looking for our other half, and he says that love is the name for the desire and pursuit of the whole (192e to 193a). Later in the same dialogue Diotima describes a ladder of love that climbs from one beautiful body to all of them, then to beautiful souls, to laws and knowledge, and finally to beauty itself (210a to 212a).
- The first letter of John says that God is love, and whoever abides in love abides in God, and God abides in him (4:16).
- The Metta Sutta, the Buddhist discourse on loving kindness, says that just as a mother would protect her only child with her life, one should cultivate a boundless heart toward all beings (Sutta Nipata 1.8).

4. The turn

Picture the run in two halves. In the first half separation is new, and it is the thing being learned. Getting more separate feels good here: my own room, my own money, my own name on the door, winning. This is the half of the game you came for, and the happiness in it is real.

Somewhere there is a bottom point, the most separate a point of view gets, and past it the signal flips. The same moves stop paying. A step toward unity starts to feel good in a way that lasts, and taking more for yourself starts to feel empty. Nobody announces it. It shows up as a flatness no new result can touch, and a quiet question of whether this is all there is. I call it the turn. It is where the third clause of the axiom, that the separation ends, starts working on one particular person.



Two halves of one game. Past the bottom point the same moves stop paying, and a step toward unity starts to.

Any room on Part one's chart can hit it. In Driven it usually looks like the crash after reaching the goal, in Drifting like the plateau, and in Default like an emptiness in a perfectly ordinary life. For me it was the weekends I mentioned in Part one, when every free hour felt empty and none of my results could reach it. Some people seem to be born after it. They never quite fit a world that runs on separation and start searching young, which from the outside can look a lot like being a difficult teenager.

The switch is hard, because everything in you was trained to move the other way. The old moves still look right and stop feeling right, so a driven person

often doubles down first. It's like pressing the elevator button harder. Everybody knows it doesn't help, and we all do it. There's a fear in it as well. If more is possible than you thought, the excuses go, and it's all back in your hands.

After the turn, happiness becomes the compass. I mean the state you live in over months: fulfillment, steady good will toward people, wanting to get up in the morning. A moment of fun comes and goes. The test is simple. Over the last year, have I become more fulfilled, or more bleak? Each of us carries our own compass, and nobody else can read it for us. If the emptiness has turned into a depression that weighs on every day, get real help first, from a doctor or a therapist. The compass will still be there afterwards.

Before the turn and after it are two halves of the same game, like a player who has played for years and one who has just started. The second will get there too. Every part of the lila is needed, which is also why the paths look so different.

> FROM THE TRADITIONS · 5 PASSAGES

Restless, and coming to yourself

- The Buddha tells his own version in the Anguttara Nikaya (3.39). He describes a delicate life in his father's house, with lotus ponds made just for him, a house for each of the three seasons and musicians for the four months of the rains. Amid all of it he reflected that he too would grow old, get sick and die, and the vanity of youth, of health and of life fell away from him. Later biographies tell the same moment as the four sights: an old man, a sick man, a corpse and a wandering monk.
- The Teacher of Ecclesiastes made himself great works, built houses, planted vineyards, gathered silver and gold and kept nothing from his eyes that they wanted. Then he looked at everything his hands had done, and all was vanity and a striving after wind (2:4 to 11).
- Augustine opens his Confessions by telling God that he made us for himself, and that our heart is restless until it rests in him (1.1).

- Rumi opens his Masnavi with a reed flute that cries because it was parted from the reed bed, and says that everyone who is left far from their source wishes back the time when they were united with it (Book I, 1 to 4).
- In the parable of the prodigal son, the younger son takes his share, leaves for a far country and spends everything. When a famine comes and he is feeding pigs, he came to himself (Luke 15:17). He goes home, and while he is still a long way off his father sees him and runs to him (15:20). That is the turn, almost word for word.

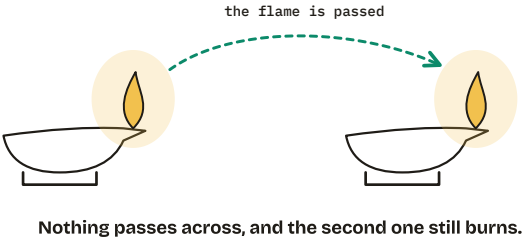
5. Something carries over

You have forgotten almost every day you have lived. Try to remember an ordinary afternoon from when you were small, and you get a blur, maybe a face or a smell. Still, the person reading this is made out of

those days. The events went, and what they taught you stayed: the patience or the lack of it, the fears, the things your hands know how to do.

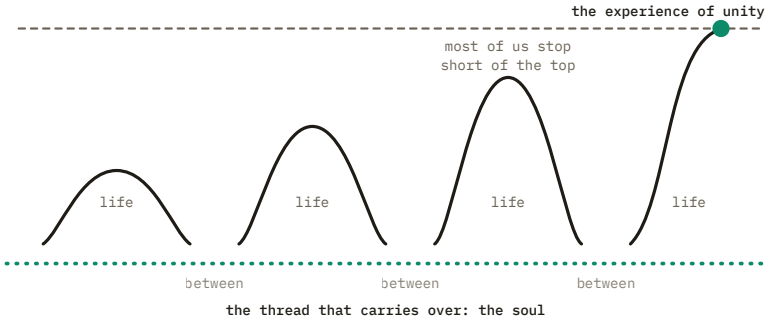
Under the axiom the same holds on the largest scale. What a life learned and what it became is kept. Most traditions call it the soul, and Buddhism, which denies a fixed self, speaks of a stream that carries on.

That something can't be the body, which stays behind. It is the part of you that was never really separate, the whole at one position, going through the separation and keeping the record. An old Buddhist dialogue has the image I like most for it: a lamp lit from another lamp, where nothing passes across and the second one still burns.



A lamp lit from another lamp.

How it carries on is where the traditions part, and the axiom doesn't need to settle it. In one family of answers it goes on after death in another form, like purgatory in Catholic teaching or the barzakh, the barrier the Quran puts between death and resurrection. In the other it comes back into this world, life after life, which Hindu texts call samsara. Either way, what this life gathered is taken further, and several traditions hold that the whole road can be walked within a single life.



What a life gathers is kept and carried on, whichever form the traditions give it.

That changes what dying is. Death is the end of one session, and the one who lived it goes on. Most of us are still afraid of it, and the axiom says why: a separate self is sure of one thing it will lose, which is itself. So the fear of dying is the wall's strongest reflex, and it eases as the wall eases. That's why so many traditions treat letting go as a practice for dying. Every small thing you stop defending while you're alive makes the last letting go a little more familiar. I still look both ways before crossing the street, twice.

> FROM THE TRADITIONS · 5 PASSAGES
>
> **Lives, afterlives, and practice for dying**

- In the Bhagavad Gita, the Hindu scripture in which the god Krishna advises the warrior Arjuna, he says that the yogi who keeps striving is perfected through many births and then reaches the highest goal (6.45), and he compares the self to a person putting on new clothes and discarding worn ones (2.22). The Buddha says that samsara, the cycle of birth, death and rebirth, has no discoverable beginning and that it is not easy to find a being who has not at some time been your mother (Samyutta Nikaya 15, in one of the oldest collections of his talks).
- Near the end of The Education of the Human Race, in 1780, Lessing, a thoroughly Enlightenment sort of person, asks why he shouldn't come back as often as he is capable of acquiring fresh knowledge.
- In the Myth of Er that closes Plato's Republic, souls choose their next lives and then drink from the river of forgetfulness before they are born, which is one old answer to why you don't

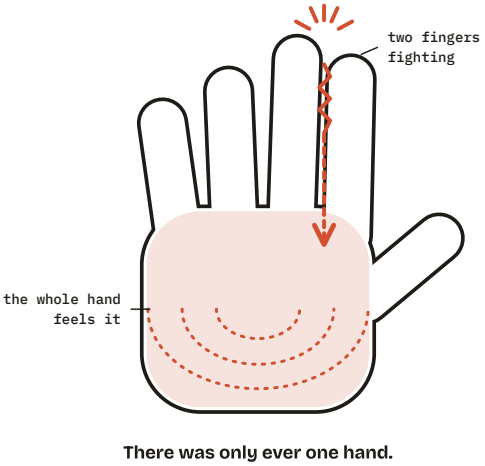
remember the last one, and the best explanation I've heard for Monday mornings.

- The lamp comes from the Milindapanha, a dialogue between King Milinda and the monk Nagasena, where the one who is reborn is neither the same nor another, like a lamp that burns all night without being the same flame from one hour to the next.
- In Plato's Phaedo, Socrates says on the day of his death that those who practice philosophy rightly are practicing nothing other than dying and being dead (64a), and that this is why death frightens them less than anyone (67e).

6. Karma, or the fingers

If we are all part of one whole, there is nobody else. Hold up your hand. If the index finger and the middle finger start fighting, pressing and

scratching, they hurt the hand, and the hand is the only thing either of them can be a part of. Nobody had to appoint a judge.



Karma, with the courtroom taken out.

Most of us have felt this from the inside. You see a small child about to fall into a well, and you feel a jolt of alarm before you've thought anything. Wang Yangming, the Chinese philosopher, used this very example in 1527, and for him the jolt is what forming one body with the child feels like from the inside.

The fingers really do believe they are separate, and every scratch one gives another lands on the same hand. That is what karma really means. The word is Sanskrit for action, and in everyday use it has turned into a ledger with a judge and a sentence. The version I hold has no judge. It works like a mirror. Someone irritates you, and that shows you a place in yourself that hasn't been mended yet.

The mirror is for looking at yourself, and only at yourself. Pointing it at someone else, you're hurting so go and work on yourself, is an abuse of the idea, and it does the most harm when a group does it to one person. When another person is in pain, compassion is the only way to treat them, and calling it their karma is just indifference. When someone is hurting you, the pain asks you to act: fight back, get help or leave. The mirror can only show you what you add on top, and that can wait until you're safe.

Before the turn, the mirror mostly shows the cost of being separate, and the bill grows until the bottom point. After the turn it becomes practical. The

irritation, the old fight with your mother, the colleague you can't stand: each one marks a spot where you still act as two. The sharpest lessons come from the people closest to you, because that is where it hurts most. When I stop reacting the old way, the other person stops getting the old reaction, and very often the whole pattern between us shifts.

A lesson that isn't learned comes back in a new costume: a new boss with the old boss's habits, a new relationship with the same argument, and, if this life runs out first, a new life with the same homework. If karma were a person, it would be a very patient tutor who keeps setting the same homework until it gets done, and I have redone some of mine more times than I'd like to admit.

> FROM THE TRADITIONS · 5 PASSAGES
>
> **Deeds come back, and the other is me**
>
> - The traditions differ on who administers karma. In the Buddhist account nobody does: the Buddha said it is intention he calls karma (Anguttara Nikaya 6.63). In Advaita, karma belongs to the world of apparent individuals.

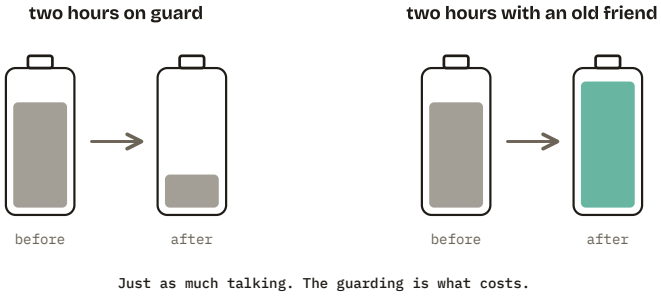
- The shape turns up elsewhere without any rebirth. Paul writes that whatever one sows, that will he also reap (Galatians 6:7), and the Quran says that if you do good, you do good for yourselves, and if you do evil, you do it to yourselves (17:7).
- The image of the fingers is old too. Paul says the church is a body with many members, and that if one member suffers, all suffer together (1 Corinthians 12:26). Shantideva, the Indian Buddhist, wrote in his Guide to the Bodhisattva's Way of Life that the hand and the other limbs are many and distinct, yet all are one, and that beings are in the same way all one in wanting happiness (Bodhicaryavatara 8.91).
- The golden rule is the same logic read forwards: if the other is me, treating them as I want to be treated stops being a nicety and becomes consistency. Hillel, asked to teach the whole Torah while standing on one foot, is reported to have said: what is hateful to you, do not do to your fellow. That is the whole

Torah, and the rest is commentary (Shabbat 31a, in the Talmud).

- Repair has its own rules. The Mishnah, an early Jewish law code, says that Yom Kippur, the Day of Atonement, atones for sins between a person and God, but for sins against another person only once that person has been appeased (Yoma 8:9). In the Sermon on the Mount, Jesus says that if you remember at the altar that your brother has something against you, you should leave your gift there and first go and be reconciled (Matthew 5:23-24). The words for repentance point the same way: the Hebrew teshuvah comes from the verb shuv, to return (it is also the everyday word for an answer), the Arabic tawba comes from a root for turning back, and the Greek metanoia means a change of mind.

7. Energy

Spend two hours with someone you have to keep your guard up around, and you come out flat. Spend the same two hours with an old friend and you come out lighter, though you talked just as much. The talking didn't use up the energy. The guarding did.

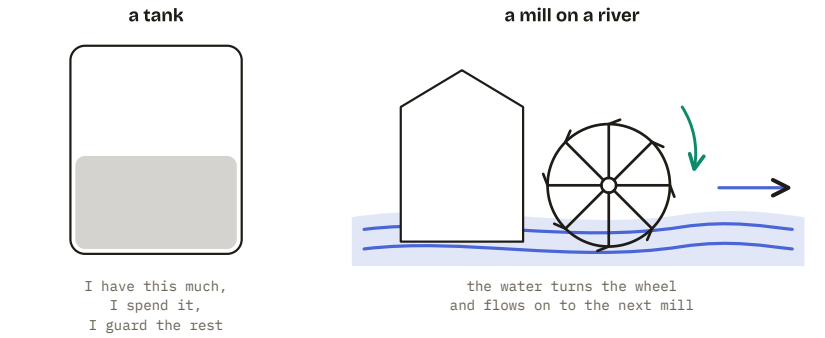


The same two hours, on guard and with an old friend.

In this step energy means your capacity to act and to be present, the fuel behind DO and BE from Part one.

The separate self treats it like a tank. I have this much, I spend it, I run out, and I guard what is left. And holding the wall costs, so a good part of the tank goes on guarding the tank.

Under the axiom it can't really work that way, because there is nothing outside the whole to take energy from and nowhere for it to leak to. A part that starts remembering the whole works more like a mill on a river. The mill doesn't drink the river. The water turns the wheel, does real work and flows on to the next mill downstream, and the mill's job is to let it through. A mill that clamps its wheel tight gets less flow. So the extra energy comes from two places, and neither one takes from anybody. Some of it is what you stop spending on the wall. The rest is what flows through once the wheel turns freely, and you have probably felt it: a night spent helping someone you love, or finishing work you care about, when you were tired by the end and somehow not empty. That is a little of the river, and the river is what I called the source at the start of this part.



A tank, and a mill on a river. The mill does not drink the river. Its job is to let the water through.

It changes how you are with people, too. Once the energy comes from the river, you stop trying to get it from the people around you. They can feel the difference, and closeness gets easier.

You can check the first half this week. The next time you come home flat, ask which it was, the talking or the guarding.

Letting go is how the wheel opens. You can't push more water through a mill by gripping the wheel harder, and every bit of guarding you drop is flow you get back. That is why so many traditions describe the way in as a kind of emptying. Hasidim

call it bittul, the Sufis fana, Christians kenosis, after Paul's line that Jesus emptied himself, and one of the Buddha's breathing instructions is to breathe while contemplating letting go.

Once more starts coming through, you notice it first in small things: the evening after a hard day isn't gone, and the talk you dreaded takes less out of you. The temptation then is to do something impressive with it.

FROM THE TRADITIONS · 6 PASSAGES

God, grace, and miracles

- As I read it, the nearest thing in the axiom to what the traditions call God is the whole, met from one position. A part can only meet the whole as someone, which is why so many traditions pray to a You. Prayer is the part turning toward the whole, grace is the river from this step arriving without being earned, and gratitude is the part noticing it. Each tradition describes God in its own way, and the examples below are here for the shape they share.

- The Quran says that God is nearer to a person than the jugular vein (50:16).
- Martin Buber, the Jewish philosopher, wrote in I and Thou in 1923 that the lines of all our relations meet in the eternal You, and that every real meeting with another as a You is a glimpse of it.
- A prayer attributed to Rabia of Basra, the early Sufi woman saint, asks that if she worships God for fear of hell, God should burn her in it, if for hope of paradise, shut her out of it, and if for God's own sake, not withhold his beauty from her.
- Concordia Antarova's novel Two Lives, one of my favorite books, keeps coming back to a single line, which I would translate as: there are no miracles, only different levels of knowledge. Under the axiom a miracle would be one of the settings from step 2 turned up a little, and it looks like magic only to someone who doesn't know the setting is there. My grandma already thinks I'm a black magician

every time I fix the computer, so I'm halfway there.

- Nearly every tradition that describes such powers also warns against chasing them. Patanjali lists them in the Yoga Sutras and then says that, however much they look like achievements to a mind still facing outward, they are obstacles to samadhi, the deepest absorption (3.37).

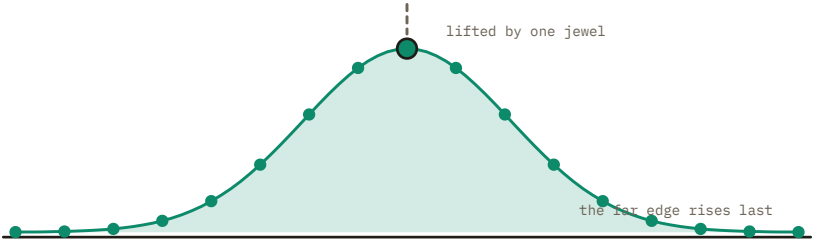
8. Lifting the cloth

Step 7 opened with two hours: one spent with someone you have to keep your guard up around, and one with an old friend you come away lighter from. Turn it around. For the people in your life you are one of those two, and which one depends a lot on how much wall you are holding that day.

That follows from the fingers. Whatever I do to another part comes back to me, so whatever I mend in myself reaches the others, and when one finger stops pressing, the finger next to it feels it first. It shows in two ways. The first you can watch from outside. A person who has stopped fighting themselves is easier to be around. They say sorry first and follow up on their words, and the people near them relax a little and sometimes start doing the same. Anyone who has had a good boss after a bad one has seen it.

The second comes from step 7. The energy was never mine, so when I stop clamping the wheel it doesn't stop at my mill. It flows on to the people I'm with, and most of all to the ones I want to help. Every bit of wall I take down on my side is wall they don't have to push against. You can check this half on your own evenings. People leave an evening with you a bit lighter or a bit flatter, and it's worth noticing which, and whether that changes as you do.

Here is the picture I use. Take a piece of cloth with small jewels sewn all over it and lay it flat on a table. Pick it up by one jewel and lift. That jewel rises first, the ones next to it come up right after, and the far corners leave the table last. Nobody pulls on them, they rise because it is one cloth. Under the axiom, a person moving back toward unity looks like that from outside. The jewels that rise most are the nearest ones, which is why the first people to notice are usually the ones you live with.



One cloth. The jewel you lift rises first, and the nearest ones rise with it.

FROM THE TRADITIONS · 5 PASSAGES

One cloth

- The Daodejing says: cultivate it in yourself, and your virtue will be real. Cultivate it in the

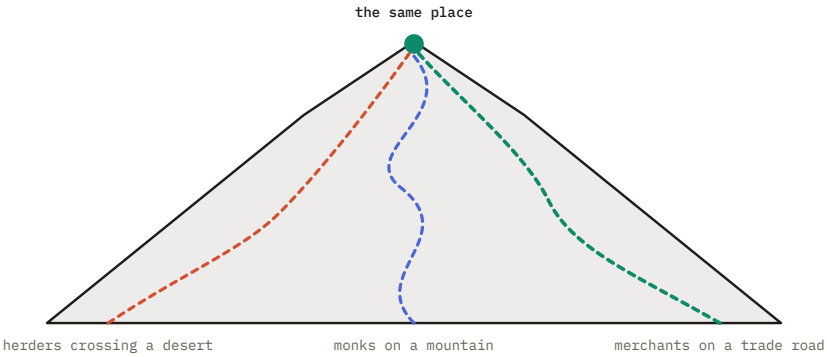
family, and it will overflow. Then the village, the country, and the world (54).

- The Great Learning, one of the Confucian classics, runs the same chain from the other end. Those who wanted to bring order to the world first put their own states in order, before that their families, and before that themselves, and it says that once the self is cultivated, the family is set right.
- Huayan Buddhism pictures the world as the net of the god Indra, with a jewel at every knot, each one reflecting all the others, so that nothing happens to one jewel alone.
- Jesus says that nobody lights a lamp to put it under a basket. It goes on a stand, and it gives light to everyone in the house (Matthew 5:15).
- A long study of one town in Massachusetts found that people's happiness tracked the happiness of their friends, and of their friends' friends (Fowler and Christakis, 2008). Other researchers have argued that part of this comes from friends sharing the same surroundings,

> or people with similar moods finding each other, so how much of it really spreads is still debated.

Why the paths differ

If one structure sits behind all this, why do the religions look so different? The whole goes into separation through countless points of view, no two of them meet the wall in the same way, and so a path is a way back drawn for particular people at a particular time. The core stays because it comes from the structure. The forms change because the people do.



A path is drawn for particular people at a particular time, and the paths meet at the same place.

You can see it in something as ordinary as a guest at the door. Abraham runs out of his tent to feed three strangers, and the story says it was God who came to him (Genesis 18). An Upanishad tells the student to treat the guest as a god (Taittiriya 1.11.2). The Prophet said that whoever believes in God and the Last Day should honor his guest (Sahih al-Bukhari 6018). Jesus says that whoever welcomed a stranger welcomed him (Matthew 25:35 to 40), and a Sikh temple kitchen, the langar, feeds anyone who walks in. A tent, a house and a temple kitchen look nothing alike, and the instruction is the same: open

the door. Under the axiom that is no surprise, since whoever is at the door is another part of the same whole.

My own road

All of this started for me with questions. Why am I alive? What is going on here? How does the world work, and the universe around it? And the one that sounds strange out loud: why am I me?

Looking for answers took me down a long road, and somewhere on it I started losing some of my walls. First I felt how connected we are, and only later did I understand it. That changed how I feel toward people and the world.

The questions are still open, and I want the answers in this lifetime, firsthand. Part one's zoom out ended on full human potential, and the whole of that map, past the corner of the chart, is where I'm headed. Along the way I want to pass on what I find,

in plain words that work, so that it helps people and makes their lives happier. That is what makes me happy, and it is my reason bigger than me.

What you can check

If the axiom is right, loosening the wall should leave marks you can check. In 1997 Robert Cialdini and colleagues found that how "one" people felt with someone in need predicted their willingness to help better than sympathy did. So the check for this part is the one in that study: how often do you feel at one with the person in front of you, and what do you do next when you do? In my experience, and in what people around me describe, the order is the same: first you start to listen, then giving shows up, unasked and without a tally, then perception clears.

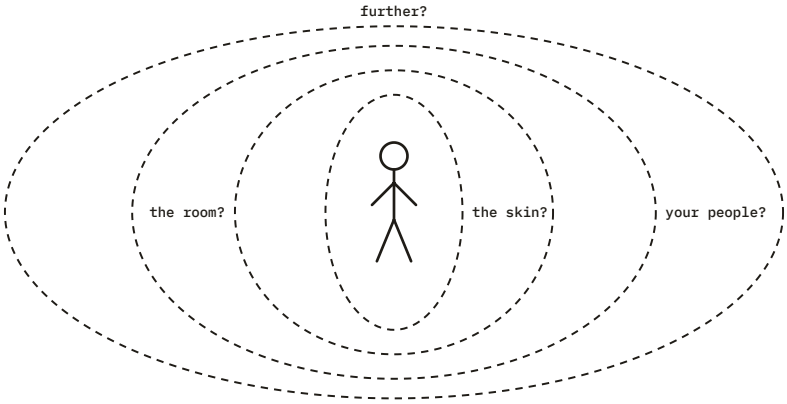
The prediction is the interesting part. If the sense of separation is held by tension, then loosening it should make a person more generous without

anyone telling them to be. It's an experiment you can run on yourself, which is the nice thing about this kind of claim.

Where this goes next

That's the map. What I haven't told you is what it takes to walk it, and that is the next part, which has a lot less philosophy in it and a lot more everyday life.

Until then, one question that needs no equipment. Where, right now, does the border of you sit?



Where, right now, does the border of you sit?

Sources

Translations: Bible verses quoted word for word follow the English Standard Version (ESV). Quran 2:115 follows Arberry, A. J. (1955), The Koran Interpreted, and Quran 17:7 and 23:100 follow the Sahih International translation. Other translators are named next to their texts below.

WHERE WE PART WAYS, AND WHY THE IDEA IS WORTH A LOOK

- Spinoza, B. Ethics, Part I (propositions 14 and 15, one substance) and the Preface to Part IV (God or Nature).
- Sagan, C. (1980). Cosmos: A Personal Voyage, episode 1, The Shores of the Cosmic Ocean.
- Chandogya Upanishad 6.8.7. Deuteronomy 6:4. John 17:21. 1 Corinthians 15:28. Quran 2:115. Daodejing 42.
- Cook, F. H. (1977). Hua-yen Buddhism: The Jewel Net of Indra. Penn State University Press.
- Shneur Zalman of Liadi, Tanya, Part II, Sha'ar ha-Yichud ve-ha-Emunah (the Gate of Unity and Faith). Chittick, W. C. (1989). The Sufi Path of Knowledge. SUNY Press.

THE AXIOM AND THE MACHINE

- Watts, A. "The Dream of Life", a recorded talk; the audio circulates from the Alan Watts archive (alanwatts.org) and the collection Out of Your Mind (Sounds True). The retelling here is a paraphrase.

1. SEPARATION IS A WAY OF LOOKING

- Plato, Republic VII (the cave). The Heart Sutra (Conze's translation, in Buddhist Wisdom Books, 1958, is the usual one). Brahma Sutra 2.1.33.
- Chittick, W. C. (1998). The Self-Disclosure of God. SUNY Press (on the hidden treasure saying).

- Emerson, R. W. (1841). The Over-Soul, in Essays: First Series.

2. HOW A WHOLE TURNS ITSELF DOWN

- Gurdon, J. B. (1962). The developmental capacity of nuclei taken from intestinal epithelium cells of feeding tadpoles. Journal of Embryology and Experimental Morphology, 10, 622-640. Takahashi, K., & Yamanaka, S. (2006). Induction of pluripotent stem cells from mouse embryonic and adult fibroblast cultures by defined factors. Cell, 126(4), 663-676. Takahashi, K., et al. (2007). Induction of pluripotent stem cells from adult human fibroblasts by defined factors. Cell, 131(5), 861-872. The Nobel Prize in Physiology or Medicine 2012, press release (Gurdon and Yamanaka).
- Tattvartha Sutra, chapter 8 (karma as the veil on the soul's knowledge).
- Kshemaraja, Pratyabhijnahrdayam (Singh, J. (1963), Pratyabhijnahrdayam: The Secret of Self-Recognition, Motilal Banarsidass). Scholem, G. (1941). Major Trends in Jewish Mysticism, lecture 7, on Isaac Luria and tzimtzum. Chandogya Upanishad 6.13 and 6.8.7.
- Mishnah, Avot 3:15.

3. THE WALL, FELT FROM INSIDE

- Augustine, Enchiridion, chapter 11.

- Samyutta Nikaya 36.6 (the Sallatha Sutta).
- Plato, Symposium 192e-193a (Aristophanes) and 210a-212a (Diotima). 1 John 4:16. Sutta Nipata 1.8 (the Metta Sutta).

4. THE TURN

- Anguttara Nikaya 3.39, the Sukhumala Sutta (Sujato's translation, SuttaCentral). The four sights are told in the later biographies, for example Ashvaghosha's Buddhacarita and the Nidanakatha.
- Ecclesiastes 2:4-11 (2:11 quoted from the ESV).
- Augustine, Confessions 1.1 (Pusey's translation of 1838 reads "our heart is restless, until it repose in Thee").
- Rumi, Masnavi, Book I, 1-4, translated by Nicholson, R. A. (1926), The Mathnawi of Jalalu'ddin Rumi, vol. II (translation of Books I and II). Gibb Memorial Trust.
- Luke 15:11-32.

5. SOMETHING CARRIES OVER

- Lessing, G. E. (1780). The Education of the Human Race, section 98 in the usual numbering.
- Bhagavad Gita 6.45 and 2.22. Samyutta Nikaya 15. Catechism of the Catholic Church, 1030-1031. Quran 23:100.
- Plato, Republic X (the Myth of Er).

- Milindapanha, translated by T. W. Rhys Davids, The Questions of King Milinda, Sacred Books of the East, vols. 35 and 36.
- Plato, Phaedo 64a and 67e.

6. KARMA, OR THE FINGERS

- Anguttara Nikaya 6.63. Galatians 6:7. Quran 17:7. 1 Corinthians 12:26. Shantideva, Bodhicaryavatara 8.91 (Padmakara Translation Group, The Way of the Bodhisattva, 2006; the wording here is a close paraphrase, and verse numbering varies a little by translation).
- Babylonian Talmud, Shabbat 31a (Hillel).
- Wang Yangming (1527). Inquiry on the Great Learning.
- Mishnah, Yoma 8:9. Matthew 5:23-24.

7. ENERGY

- Bittul in the Hasidic tradition. Fana in the Sufi tradition. Philippians 2:5-8. Majjhima Nikaya 118.
- Quran 50:16. Buber, M. (1923). I and Thou (Ich und Du). The prayer attributed to Rabia of Basra in the Sufi tradition (retold in later sources).
- Antarova, K. E. Two Lives (Две жизни), Part I: «нет чудес, а есть та или иная степень знания». The English

is the author's own translation.

- Patanjali, Yoga Sutras 3.37, numbered as in Johnston, C. (1912), The Yoga Sutras of Patanjali: The Book of the Spiritual Man.

8. LIFTING THE CLOTH

- Daodejing 54 (Legge's translation, Sacred Books of the East, vol. 39). The Great Learning (Daxue), the opening section (Legge's translation, The Chinese Classics, vol. 1). Cook, F. H. (1977). Hua-yen Buddhism: The Jewel Net of Indra. Penn State University Press. Matthew 5:15.

- Fowler, J. H., & Christakis, N. A. (2008). Dynamic spread of happiness in a large social network: longitudinal analysis over 20 years in the Framingham Heart Study. BMJ, 337, a2338. Cohen-Cole, E., & Fletcher, J. M. (2008). Detecting implausible social network effects in acne, height, and headaches: longitudinal analysis. BMJ, 337, a2533. Shalizi, C. R., & Thomas, A. C. (2011). Homophily and contagion are generically confounded in observational social network studies. Sociological Methods & Research, 40(2), 211-239.

WHY THE PATHS DIFFER

- Genesis 18:1-8. Taittiriya Upanishad 1.11.2. Sahih al-Bukhari 6018. Matthew 25:35-40. The langar, the free kitchen of the Sikh gurdwara.

WHAT YOU CAN CHECK

- Cialdini, R. B., Brown, S. L., Lewis, B. P., Luce, C., & Neuberg, S. L. (1997). Reinterpreting the empathy-altruism relationship: When one into one equals oneness. Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 73(3), 481-494. doi:10.1037/0022-3514.73.3.481

PART THREE

Practical

How this is done today, by people with jobs, families and not much spare time.

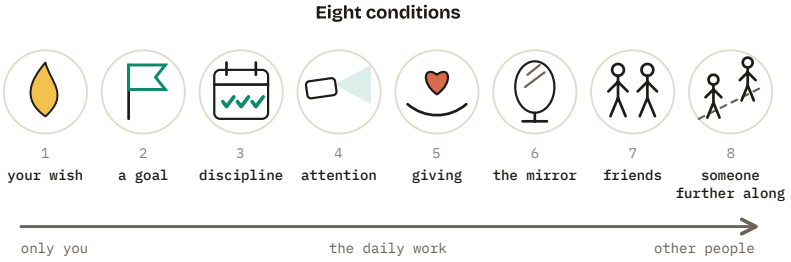
◇

If your life is going well and feels well, you have no need of a method. Part two drew the road back to remembering that we are part of something bigger, and life moves all of us along it anyway, slowly, through the mirror and the turn. Nobody has to finish it in one life. A method is a way to do on purpose, and faster, what life does slowly.

This part is about walking the whole road in one life, past the small square and into the large one, until we are free of our own limitations. As far as I can see, that comes down to conditions, and I count

eight. When all eight are in a person's life, finishing the road is a realistic plan. When one of them is missing, the road gets much longer.

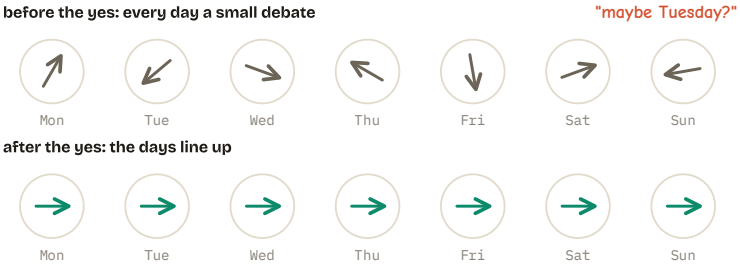
The old traditions built every one of these conditions long before us, and they can be found or built in many places. Read them as a list to hold your own life against. The order goes from what only you can supply, through the daily work, to what comes from other people.



Eight conditions, in the order of this part.

1. Your wish, and your yes

Think of a time you really decided something: a move, a new job, a person. Before it, every day was a small debate. After it, the days started to line up, and things you had been putting off began to happen almost on their own.



Before the yes, every day is a small debate. After it, the days line up.

That yes stands on a wish, and the wish is the one condition nobody else can supply. Part two said the whole handed the steering to each point of view, so nobody can start the return for you. A mentor can point and friends can lift you, and none of them can want it for you.

People come for all kinds of reasons, and the reasons change along the way. Some come with questions about why we exist. Some want to stay calm when the inbox explodes. Some simply can't sleep and want to feel better, which is reason enough to start. Which one is yours matters less than that it is really yours.

FROM PEOPLE'S LIVES · 8 EXAMPLES

What if I'm not sure?

FROM THE OUTSIDE:

- For driven people it is usually a crash: burnout, a body that stops cooperating, or a depression that lands right after the goal is reached.
- Something happens to someone close, a relative in the hospital or a partner's betrayal, and values shift.
- The founder in Part one kept building up tension until the old way stopped working, and out of options went on a retreat.
- For one friend of mine it was a single talk. After years of trying everything spiritual, my

friend decided it was all nonsense, went into business, and within months felt empty. One talk by my teacher was enough to sense that the point was the middle of Part one's chart, letting go and action together.

FROM THE INSIDE:

- Some feel an emptiness that results can't reach. For me it showed up whenever I had time to myself, and it made the weekends the worst part of the week.
- Others have nothing to complain about, and a quiet question shows up anyway: is this all there is?
- Some reach a plateau, years of calm and comfort, until the calm itself starts to feel pointless.
- And some only feel that something is off, with no event to point at.

How you come to this says nothing about how ready you are for it. One of the students whose example I learn from most started because of

trouble sleeping, and the idea itself met years of resistance. Today that student is one of the people I look up to most.

A wish is the wanting, and a decision is the yes that goes with it, the moment the wanting becomes a direction. It can be quiet, a sentence you say to yourself on an ordinary evening. After it you no longer bargain with yourself every morning about whether today counts, and the energy the bargaining took goes into living. Many traditions call this the greatest victory there is, the one over yourself.

FROM THE TRADITIONS · 5 PASSAGES

The greatest victory

- In the Dhammapada the supreme conqueror is the one who conquers a single person, himself, and the verse sets that above winning a battle against a million. Another verse says no god, and not even Mara, the tempter of the Buddhist stories, can undo the victory of

someone who has tamed themselves (103 to 105).

- In Pirkei Avot Ben Zoma asks who is mighty, and answers: the one who subdues his inclination. He backs it with Proverbs, which says it is better to have self-control than to conquer a city (4:1, quoting Proverbs 16:32).
- The Jain Uttaradhyayana has almost the same verse as the Dhammapada. King Nami, who has given up his throne, answers Indra, king of the gods, that a man may conquer thousands and thousands of valiant foes, and greater will be his victory if he conquers nobody but himself (chapter 9).
- The Daodejing says that whoever overcomes others is strong, and whoever overcomes himself is mighty (33).
- A hadith in Sahih al-Bukhari reports the Prophet saying that the strong one is the one who controls himself while in anger, which he sets against overcoming people by strength (6114).

The wish has its days, a lift on some and a slump on others, and a low day ranks nobody. It's a day. The wish also grows. A goal you love feeds it, and a bigger wish crowds out smaller ones, so you don't have to fight the small ones one at a time. What drains it fastest is feeling sorry for yourself, and a half-wish that changes its mind every Tuesday about how much it's willing to give.

You can see from the outside how strong a wish is. A project that never gets built, a plan that stays a plan: the wish behind it was probably weaker than it felt. I still have a few of those myself. So ask yourself how much you want this, and take the answer as information. Then do something concrete, and say yes again tomorrow.

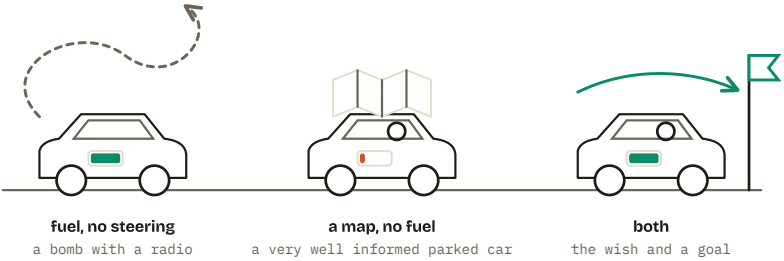
> TRY IT
>
> **Your sentence, and the yes you already know**
>
> - Write one sentence that starts "I want this because", in your own words, and keep it somewhere you'll see it. In a month, read it

again and ask whether it still sounds like you or like something you read somewhere.

- Then remember a time you really decided something. Write down what changed in the days after, and ask what the same yes would sound like here.

2. A goal, and a reason

Anything that moves needs two things, energy and direction. A car with plenty of fuel and no steering is a bomb with a radio. A car with a perfect map and no fuel is a very well informed parked car. The wish is the fuel, and a goal is the steering.

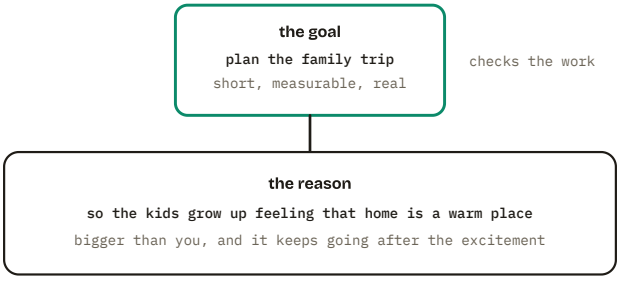


The wish is the fuel, and a goal is the steering.

Inner growth is easy to fake, even to yourself. A calm sit feels like progress whether or not anything has changed. So you set outer goals and judge the inner work by them. A good goal takes weeks or months, ends in a clear yes or no, and lives in the world where other people can see it. Plan the family trip for the summer. Finish a draft of an essay. A goal you care about also pulls effort out of you that plain willpower never would.

Behind each goal sits a reason, and the reason is what keeps you going after the first excitement wears off. The goal can be small as long as the reason is bigger than you, which is the pull from Part one. You plan the family trip because you want

your kids to grow up feeling that home is a warm place. You finish the draft because someone out there may need what is in it.



The goal can be small as long as the reason is bigger than you.

Results are how you check the work, and they are never the aim. If you start chasing them for their own sake, you've rebuilt the Driven room with better vocabulary. Without any goal, the inner work has nothing to be checked against, and it can feel like growth for years while nothing moves.

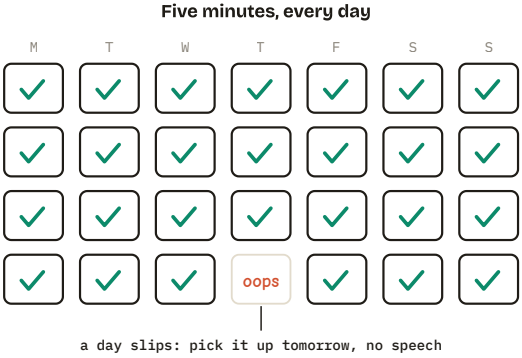
> TRY IT
>
> **What is behind the goal**

- Take a goal you have now, or something you'd like to be different in a month. Under it write "because", and finish the sentence. Then ask "and why do I want that?" a few times over, until you reach something that feels true and a little surprising. Sometimes that is the reason to keep in front of you, and sometimes it shows the goal was standing in for something else.

3. Discipline

Part two's step 2 ended on a pull that only goes one way: do nothing in particular and you end up a little more separate every year. A pull that never takes a day off can only be matched by something that doesn't take one either, and that is discipline, doing what you decided to do after the mood for it has passed.

Keep it light, and keep it yours: a demand you make on yourself, in a friendly tone. Gritting your teeth through practice adds tension, which is the very thing practice is there to remove. Discipline that runs on pride runs down like a battery, and what keeps it going for years is that you start to enjoy it. Five minutes every day is a frame you can keep, and a frame you keep teaches your mind that you can trust your own word. When a day slips, pick it up the next day without a speech about it.



A frame you can keep. When a day slips, pick it up the next day.

It grows from the outside in. A fixed time and a meeting on the calendar are the outside, and you can keep them even on a day when you don't feel like it. After a while you see what they give you, and the keeping starts to come from you.

For me it looks like this. I've dedicated my life to the spiritual path, and it's my focus every day. That's why I do the three meditations a day, every day, and why I can't just stop taking part in something because I don't feel like it that day. Another thing I'm disciplined about is alcohol, cigarettes and drugs: a hundred percent no to all of them. It's a way of life, and discipline is a big part of it.

Without discipline, direction follows mood, and mood brings back the swing from Part one.

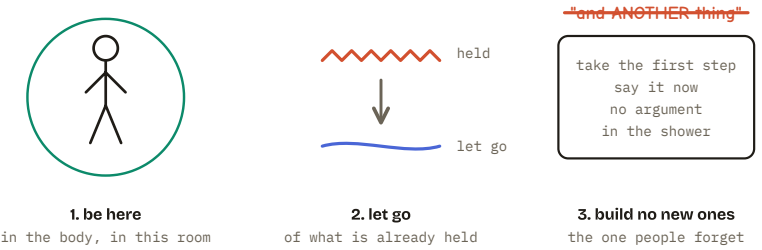
> TRY IT
>
> **One promise, and the bargain**
>
> - Each morning for ten days, promise yourself one small thing, then do it and mark it done. If the ten days hold, go for a month. Keep it small

enough to feel almost silly. What you're building is a word to yourself that holds.

- When you catch yourself negotiating, "I'll start tomorrow" or "today doesn't really count", write down the exact sentence your mind used. After two weeks, read the list. Most minds turn out to have three or four favorite lines, and mine are not very original.

4. Work with attention

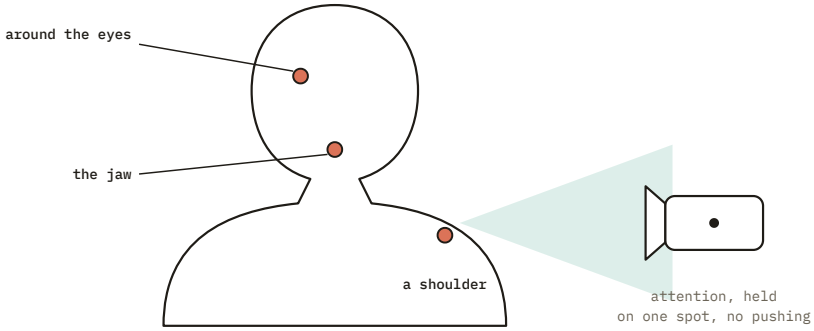
Part two said the belief that I'm separate is held in the body as tension, and that suffering is the grip we add around the pain. That puts the most direct work in the body, with attention, and it has three jobs.



The three jobs of attention.

The first is to be here, in the body and in this room, with no detour through later. This is the plainest meaning of BE from Part one: how much of you is actually present for what is happening right now. It sounds trivial until you try to keep it for a minute.

The second job is letting go of the tension you've already built up. Tension sits in the body as clamps, and you can find them: a jaw, a shoulder, the muscles around the eyes. Attention is the tool. You put it on the clamp and keep it there, like a flashlight held on one spot, and you don't push, because pushing is more tension. Eventually the clamp goes.



Attention held on a clamp like a flashlight on one spot, with no pushing.

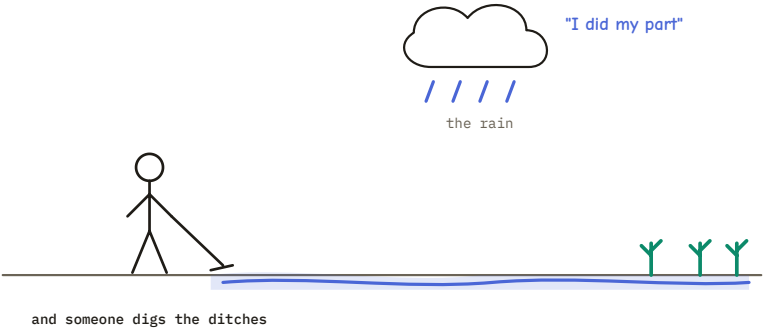
Stillness is the simplest form of this, and you can start tonight, alone. Close your eyes and feel the life in your body. Put your attention on that sensation, and learn to gain pleasure from it. That's the whole instruction. Start with five minutes, and sit longer or more often whenever you like. It's also where to look for the border of you that Part two asked about. You don't need to agree with anything in this book to try it, and five minutes will tell you more about it than I can.



Most days I sit like this two or three times. The beard is not part of the method.

Prayer is the same attention pointed somewhere else. In stillness it rests on the body, and in prayer it turns toward the whole, which here means learning to talk with life itself. One way in is a question: how would you talk if you met God, or whatever you call the source? You would take off the masks and speak

as you are. Asking is part of it, for help and for other people, and the asking tends to turn toward giving. You can tell the conversation is real the way you can tell a person is really listening to you. And prayers alone don't bring rain. Someone has to dig the ditches for it.

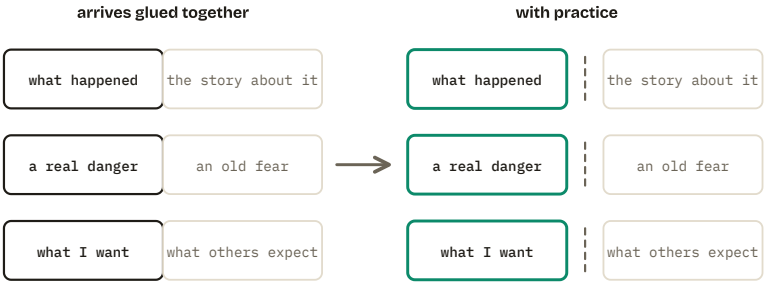


Prayers alone don't bring rain, and someone has to dig the ditches for it.

The third job is not to build new tension, and it's the one people forget. If you clear your shoulders in the morning and spend the day clenching, you've bailed a boat with the hole still open. It mostly comes down to small choices, like saying the sentence now

instead of carrying it, and not rehearsing the argument in the shower. Each of them is a clamp that never forms.

Underneath all three there's a plain skill: seeing your own mind at work. Most of what you do in a day gets triggered. Someone says a thing, something fires, and you've answered before you've decided to. One tool I use: when something fires, notice where it lands in the body, the jaw or the stomach, and look at it there for a moment before you answer. Over time, things that usually arrive glued together start to come apart: what happened and the story I tell myself about it, a real danger and an old fear, what I actually want and what someone else expects of me.



What usually arrives glued together starts to come apart.

The daily sit is the smallest part of the practice. What it changes is the rest of the day, at the checkout and in the argument. Your family, your work, your health and the people you live with are where the practice really happens, and where you find out whether anything has changed. Some weeks the five minutes feel flat and nothing seems to happen. Those dry stretches end, and they end for the people who kept sitting through them. Without the practice, you clear the clamps in the morning and build new ones all day, and the drift does the rest.

> TRY IT
>
> **Five minutes, then two columns**

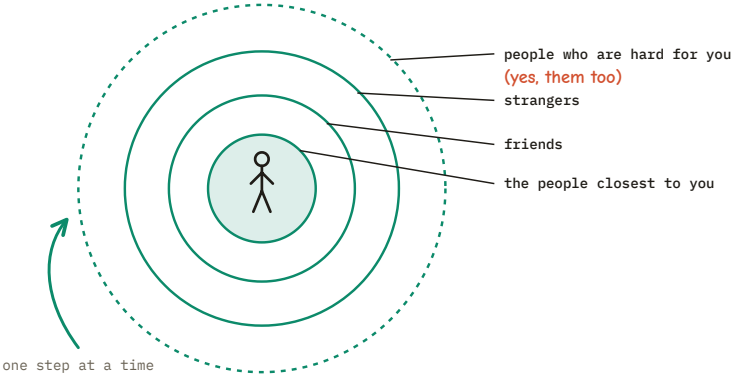
- Once a day, do the five minutes of stillness from this section: close your eyes, feel the life in your body, put your attention on that sensation, and learn to enjoy it. If that's all you do, it's plenty.
- If you'd like to take it further, open your eyes afterwards and think of one hard moment from the day. Write two columns: what happened, and the story you told yourself about it. After a few minutes of stillness the two are much easier to tell apart.

5. Giving

Giving here means putting effort into the good of other people, or of something bigger than you, without counting what comes back. An hour of real attention counts. So does using your skills on

someone else's problem. This is where the reason bigger than you from section 2 turns into something you do.

It starts with the people closest to you, which is also where the cloth from Part two rises first. By the logic of the fingers, helping you is helping me, as a matter of plumbing, with niceness left out of it. The circle widens from there, one ring at a time, toward the people who are hard for you.



It starts with the people closest to you, and the circle widens from there.

Give without conditions. Don't demand thanks, recognition or a result in return, and don't hold the person hostage to the goal behind it, however big that goal is. While you're busy with something larger than yourself, there is less of you to guard, and that speeds up the one thing almost nothing else touches, the slow change in the ego. My one-line summary of the whole road, for anyone in a hurry: get over yourself. What wears away is the part of us that keeps defending, and what is left is what we bring into the world. If you're the person who already gives until nothing is left, it works the other way round for you: rest, a no and a boundary are your hard step, because an empty tank helps nobody.

Without giving, inner work can go in a circle, polishing the same stone. Giving sends the energy somewhere, the way the mill in Part two lets the river through, and other people can tell you whether it helped. Part one's two questions work here too: would you still do it if nobody ever found out, and does it make you gentler with the person in front of you?

TRY IT

One ring further out

- Draw rings on a page for the people around you, from the closest out to the people who are hard for you, and remember that the hardest one may be at home. This week, do one small thing for someone one ring further out than you usually go. When that starts to feel easy, go one more ring.

6. Mirror work and ego work

Part two said that what happens to you works like a mirror. A colleague's tone, a partner's silence, a stranger in traffic: whatever hooks me points at something in me that still needs work. Here that becomes a working rule: I take responsibility for what happens around me. That never means letting people hurt you.

It sounds like an insult and it's closer to a lever. I can't control the world, and I can control myself, so the only place I can ever change a result is on my side of it. I don't need to work out whose fault it was. I go first, I say sorry first, and I check what shifted.

When someone harms you, you react, and sometimes the right reaction is to walk away or even fight back. The mirror asks about the state the reaction comes from: do I do it because I see it as the best course, or because hate or fear is deciding for me? The same step away can be a clear choice or a flinch, and from outside they look identical. There's no beating yourself up in it either, because guilt is another clamp. The mirror is something you hold up to yourself, and holding it up to someone else is a way of skipping the work.

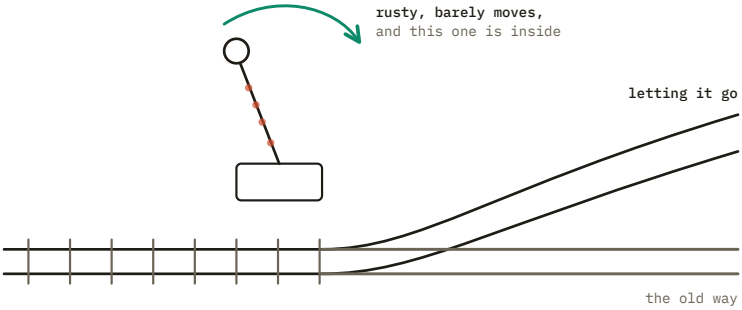


The same step away can be a clear choice or a flinch.

The clearest case I have is someone on the path I worked with very closely. This person was very stubborn and very emotional, and once the emotion rose, nothing I said landed. In that period I was learning that if we make the internal decision to change our relationship to another person or to a situation, we can change it almost at once, and that this internal click is one of the biggest keys to growing. I decided to take it seriously.

Then we had an enormous fight. I got crazy angry because once again the other person would not understand what I was trying to say, and I said we should stop and go our separate ways for a moment. I sat in another room, livid, asking how I could

change my relationship to this and how I could let it go. It was close to prayer. It felt like the lever on a railway track in the cartoons, the one that is supposed to switch the rails and is so rusty it barely moves, except that this lever was inside me. Moving it was one of the hardest things I have done. After about ten minutes it moved.



The lever was so rusty it barely moved. After about ten minutes it moved.

I went to find the other person to apologize. Calming down quickly after a fight had never been this person's way, and the anger could last for days. But by the time I had said my first word, I could see this person was already in a completely different state. So I learned that the internal click is possible

and that it works. I did it a few more times over the years, it got easier each time, and it was never that hard again. I haven't been that angry in many years.

That is what repair looks like: quick and light. A person who says "I'm sorry, that was me" the same afternoon, without an essay, has removed a clamp, and one who leaves it for a week has added one. The usual suspects behind the hook are pride, offense and the habit of judging, and the work on them has a name, ego work, which is a grand title for noticing them every time they show up. You can't see which hooks you have until someone leans on them, and the people already in your life do that every day.

TRY IT

Go first, and mean it

- Pick one conflict that is still open, big or small. This week, take the first step. Say sorry for your part in one sentence, without an essay and without a "but" at the end, and then watch what shifts.
- The hardest part is to really mean it, and meaning it takes the lever moving inside you.

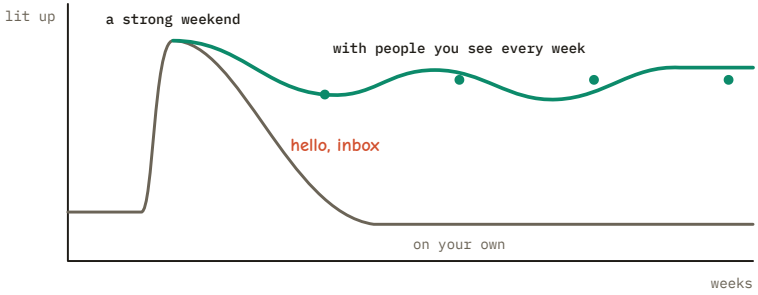
> If it won't move yet, ask yourself how you could change your relationship to this, and go when you can say it and mean it. Give it time, and don't let the time turn into years.

7. Friends on the path

Part two said the world is built to be convincing, and that a cell stays well only while it keeps listening to its neighbors. So what you are surrounded by matters as much as what you do on your own, and the strongest help you can have is a few people in your life who are working on the same thing. On your own the wish dies down faster.

This matters more now than it used to. Most of us grew up in a world that is always offering something new and telling us that a good life means getting what you want, and even a cave doesn't quite undo that, because you carry it in with you. A state can change in a day. A way of living changes

when the people around you keep pointing the same way, week after week, which is what the Buddhist sangha, the Hindu ashram and the Christian monastery were all built for.



A strong weekend, on your own and with people you see every week. An illustration, not data.

FROM THE TRADITIONS · 4 PASSAGES

Built long before us

- The Buddhist refuges are three: I take refuge in the Buddha, I take refuge in the Teaching, I take refuge in the Sangha, the community (Khuddakapatha 1).
- In Pirkei Avot Joshua ben Perahiah says: appoint for yourself a teacher, and acquire for yourself a companion (1:6).

- The Vivekachudamani, traditionally attributed to Shankara, names three things that are rare and come by the grace of God: a human birth, the longing for liberation, and the shelter of a great soul (3).
- The Rule of Benedict says a hermit goes out alone only after long probation in a monastery, having learned with the help of many brethren. Of the monks who live without a shepherd it says that their law is the desire for self-gratification: whatever enters their mind or appeals to them, that they call holy (chapter 1).

Two friends doing this together are the smallest community, and it grows from there. There are many communities on this road, and the one to look for is the one where you feel at home and find yourself growing. Among people who want the same thing, the other conditions in this part happen together and in company.

Friends on the path hold you up in the hard moments. When your mood falls through the floor, your friend's hasn't. I tend to be the one who holds others, but I have my moments too, most often when I've set myself a goal and haven't reached it, or a deadline is close and the task looks unmanageable. I used to get very hard on myself then, and my close friends helped me come back to myself, calm down and let it go.

None of this replaces the people you already have. Most of us do it alongside family, old friends and a job, and those people tend to notice the change before we do.

It comes with conditions. The people have to be aimed at the same thing, whatever words each of them uses for it. The group has to settle its conflicts quickly, by talking them through without attacking anyone, and keep the agreements it makes. When two people disagree, the way out is often a third option: keep talking until you find one you both like better than either first idea. A quarrel reverses the effect: the same closeness that lifts a community

weighs it down when there is a wall between two of its people. And the people have to want it. A community multiplies whatever is put into it, and anything times nothing is still nothing, a fact your math teacher would confirm.

When your own spark drops, lighting up a friend gets some of it back. Ananda, the Buddha's attendant, once said that good friends are half of the spiritual life, and the Buddha answered that they are the whole of it.

TRY IT

Find one person

- Is there one person in your life who wants something like what you want? Suggest a weekly walk or call where each of you says what you're working on and how the week went. If nobody in your life wants this yet, do it on your own for a while, and ask a friend who doesn't share it to check in with you anyway.
- If you both feel like it, make one small agreement together, for example five minutes

> of stillness every day for a month, and check in once a week on how you kept it.

8. Someone further along

Part two said that a limit you are inside of rarely shows up as a limit. That is true of every one of us, teachers included, the way everyone hears your accent except you. A person a few steps ahead can often name in one sentence a habit you would take years to find alone, and you can check it against your own life the same week.

A few steps is the useful distance, close enough that you can see how they got there and far enough that you want what they have. You have probably felt a small version of this already: an afternoon with the calmest person you know, and you leave a little calmer without having done anything.

It works the way a blacksmith learns. There is no syllabus. The apprentice stands next to the smith for years, watching how long the iron stays in the fire and what the smith does when a piece comes out wrong, and one day can do things nobody ever explained. Most of what you are learning here is like that: how to stay steady when a plan falls apart, how to say sorry first without making a ceremony of it. You pick it up the way you pick up an accent from a roommate, without trying, and it is a big part of why people mature much faster with a mentor than alone. Horse trainers know a version of this: a young, nervous horse runs steadier behind an older, calmer one.

TRY IT

Ask for one sentence

- Ask someone you trust: “What’s one habit of mine you think I don’t see?” Then listen and say thank you, without defending it. That same week, check what they said against your own life and see how often it shows up.

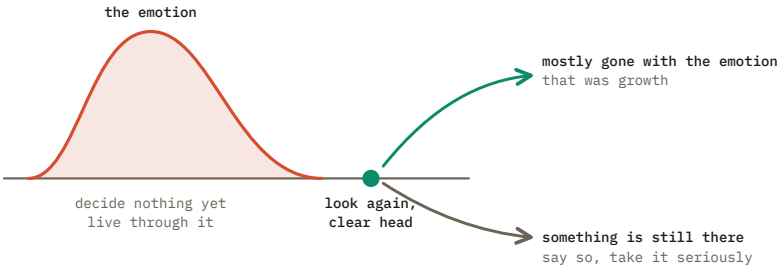
A community has energy, and it can still be going in a circle. A teacher, someone who has walked much more of the road, can see where it is growing and where it is stuck. A teacher can't walk the path for you or create your wish to walk it, which stays yours. What a teacher can do is point out where you have drifted, give you something to try on Monday, and on the hard days help you remember what you came for. A good teacher also has a steadiness that spreads, the way a calm guide on a mountain path steadies everyone walking behind.

A note on community and the teacher

The way to judge a teacher and a group is your own experience. Does this person know more than I do? Does this group actually live the values it talks about? Can I say I disagree and still be welcome, could I leave without a fight, and do I grow when I listen to this teacher? People do leave our

community, too. Some go on along their path in new ways, and some come back after a while, and we stay friends whatever they chose.

There will be moments, plenty of them, when what you think is very different from what you're offered to try. That discomfort comes to everyone who walks this road, whoever the teacher is, and with no teacher at all. For me there is one way to tell growth from something being wrong. The discomfort of growth comes together with an emotion in my body, so I decide nothing while the emotion is still there. I live through it first, and then I look at the disagreement again with a clear head. Usually most of it has gone with the emotion. When something was still there, I said so, and people took it up. Whether that's a reason to stay or to leave is up to you.



Decide nothing while the emotion is there. Look again with a clear head, and take seriously what is still there.

The hardest thing to convey is the inner decision that this is a person whose view of me I trust, and that comes only through your own experience. And you don't have to have a teacher at all. I studied on my own for years before I found mine, and it's the slower road, but it is a road.

The cloth and the world

Start with something small. You want something, a new phone, a trip, a better job, and you get it. For a week it shines, then it's just there, and the wanting

has already moved on to the next thing. That's the need setting from Part two, and the 21st century turned up everything that feeds it.

Now picture the same need with all of us behind it, a whole civilization reaching for the next thing. That reaching built a lot of what I'm grateful for, including the laptop I'm writing this on. It also runs into limits. The climate is changing, and the machines we build are getting more capable faster than we can agree on what to do with them. A lot of what makes these problems hard is that everyone guards their own corner, even when that leaves all of us worse off, which is the wall from Part two at a bigger scale.

This is usually the point where a book like this one asks you to save the world, and I'm going to do the opposite. What this work does for the world is what the cloth from Part two does. Lift one jewel and the ones next to it rise right after, and it starts with the people around you.

It’s the least glamorous way to help I know of. From the outside nothing was saved. Your partner had an easier evening. A colleague stopped bracing before meetings with you. A quarrel in your family ended a day sooner than it used to. The reason to do this work stays the wish from section 1, and what it does for the world comes by itself.

In practice, no magic happens. Part one called tension a tax on seeing solutions, and people who carry less of it see more of the shelf. They listen longer, say sorry first, and can stay at a table with someone they disagree with, which is what hard shared problems ask of us. None of it replaces the scientists, the engineers, or anyone who votes and negotiates. It changes the people who do those things. A few steady people in a family or a team change the weather in the room, and the first room is the one you live in.

What you can check

Start with a count: which of the eight conditions does your life have now, and which one is missing? After a few months of practice, ask: do you produce the thing you said you would? Does anything outside you change, and if it doesn't, why not? How fast do you say sorry first now? Over the last year, are you more fulfilled, or more bleak? Put the answers on the chart from Part one, and ask again a month later. Look at the people a few steps ahead of you, too: do they live the way they talk? And do the people closest to you leave an evening with you a bit lighter or a bit flatter?

And one question for the road: who in your life could tell you honestly how you have changed?

That's the whole road as I see it, from a chart about getting things done to the bigger map past it. I'm walking it in this life and I mean to finish it. How far you go is your own yes, and nobody can say it for you.

Sources

1. YOUR WISH, AND YOUR YES

- Dhammapada 103 to 105 (Sujato's translation, SuttaCentral).
- Pirkei Avot 4:1 (Kulp's translation, Sefaria), quoting Proverbs 16:32 (Jewish Publication Society translation).
- Uttaradhyayana Sutra, chapter 9 (Jacobi's translation, Sacred Books of the East, vol. 45).
- Daodejing 33 (Legge's translation).
- Sahih al-Bukhari 6114.

7. FRIENDS ON THE PATH

- Khuddakapatha 1, the Three Refuges (Sujato's translation, SuttaCentral).
- Pirkei Avot 1:6 (Kulp's translation, Sefaria).
- Vivekachudamani, verse 3 (Sanskrit text with Madhavananda's translation, Advaita Ashrama).
- The Rule of Benedict, chapter 1 (Doyle's translation).
- Samyutta Nikaya 45.2, the Upaddha Sutta (Sujato's translation, SuttaCentral).

AFTER THE BOOK

Stay in contact

Thank you for reading all the way here.

If you'd like to hear about workshops or online events I lead in the future, or you just have a question you'd like to ask me, feel free to leave your details below. They come straight to me, and I'll do my best to reply within a few days.

You can leave your details at rationalspiritualpractical.com/contact.